

Thursday, August 13, 2026

mint

Think Ahead. Think Growth.

mint primer

Why the Centre is against states taxing minerals

BY N. MADHAVAN

On Monday, the Union government introduced a Bill in Parliament that seeks to bar states from taxing minerals. If passed, the law will provide a welcome relief to the mining sector. *Mint* explains how minerals have been historically taxed and the significance of the proposed law.



MINT

1 What is the new Bill about?

The Union government is amending the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Act, 1957, by introducing a new section, 9D, which specifically prohibits states from imposing any levies on mined minerals. It states "no tax, cess or such other levy (by whatever name called) shall be imposed by the state government on mineral rights; or mineral bearing lands, either based on mineral quantity, mineral value, royalty or otherwise, except in accordance with such conditions or restrictions as may be prescribed by the Central Government". The amendment comes two years after the Supreme Court upheld states' right to tax minerals. It, however, exempts the states from refunding the taxes collected so far.

TURN TO PAGE 6

QUICK EDIT

Tata Sons surprise

N. Chandrasekaran's decision not to seek reappointment as chairman of Tata Sons once his term ends in February led a rout on Wednesday in the market value of this business group's listed stocks, some of which fell more than indices and industry peers. TCS, which he once ran, took an especially hard hit. He took charge at the Tata holding company's helm in 2017, and his observation that he no longer had the board's unanimous backing is seen as the reason for not wanting to stay on in one of corporate India's most prestigious roles. Earlier reports had suggested that Chandrasekaran was under pressure from Tata Sons' majority owner Tata Trusts, whose leadership was taken over by Noel Tata after Ratan Tata's demise in 2024, on the paths-to-profit of the group's unlisted businesses. Perspectives within are also said to have diverged over whether the holding company should go public. Chandrasekaran's tenure saw the conglomerate make many strategic moves, particularly in high-tech areas. A group with millions of stakeholders across India must ensure an orderly transition at the top that shields Tata shares from excessive volatility. The search for a new chief mustn't take too long.



FAST PITCH

5 minutes to tell a story
A lifetime to change one

10 causes worth listening to!

REAL CHANGEMAKERS. REAL IMPACT.
YOU DECIDE WHAT MOVES YOU!



Aftercare for youth leaving orphanages (Pan-India)



Education access for migrant children (Pune, MH)



Restoring sight/corneal blindness (Amravati, MH)



Ending menstrual isolation (Gadchiroli, MH)



Organic farming for tribal families (Uttara Kannada, KA)



Inclusion for intellectual disabilities (Villupuram, TN)



Free NEET coaching for tribal students (Pune, MH)



Fighting anaemia in mothers & children (Kallakurichi, TN)



Foundational literacy for young children (Vadodara, GJ)



Freeing children from child labour (Jalgaon, MH)

JOIN THIS VIRTUAL EVENT TODAY REGISTER NOW!

All non-profits have a fascinating story to tell. SVP Fast Pitch helps them tell it.

13TH AUGUST
5:30 PM ONWARDS

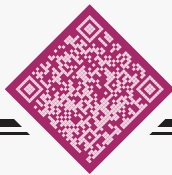
VIRTUAL ON
YOUTUBE LIVE

SCAN TO REGISTER



NOW

This message is supported by a well-wisher.



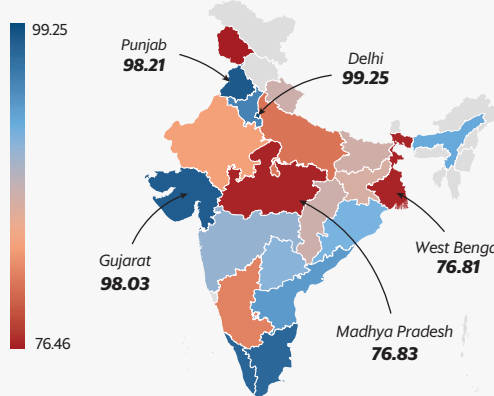
WHAT IS AILING GOVT SCHOOLS IN STATES?

BY RUPANJAL CHAUHAN & PRAGYA SRIVASTAVA

Shutdowns, declining enrolments, and lack of proper facilities in government and government-aided schools have gripped the country. *Mint* looks at how different states are performing on these parameters.

Several northern states lag in government school spread and infrastructure

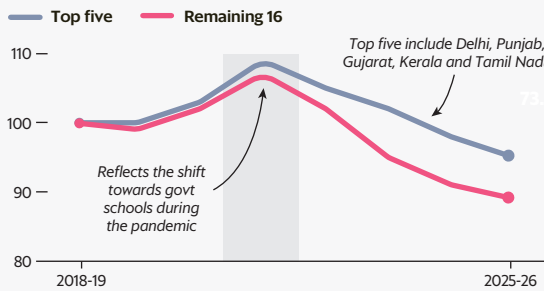
Composite score* (out of 100) on govt school status, 2025-26



*Composite scores are based on a weighted average of eight indicators: number of government and government-aided schools and enrolment relative to 2018-19 (17.39% each), access to electricity, drinking water and toilets (13.04% each), and access to library, computers and internet (8.7% each). States and UTs with a population of over 10 million are shown.

States with better government school facilities have shown a slower enrolment decline

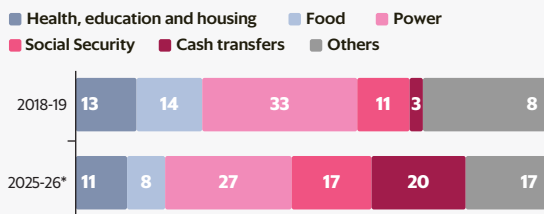
Relative movement in govt* school enrolment (rebased, 2018-19=100)



*Refers to both government and government-aided schools. 21 states and UTs with a population of over 10 million were categorized based on a weighted score of six key facilities: electricity, drinking water, and toilets (20% each) and libraries, computers and internet (13% each).

Rise in cash transfers threatens to crowd out public investment in education

Sectoral break-up of subsidies and transfer schemes (in %)

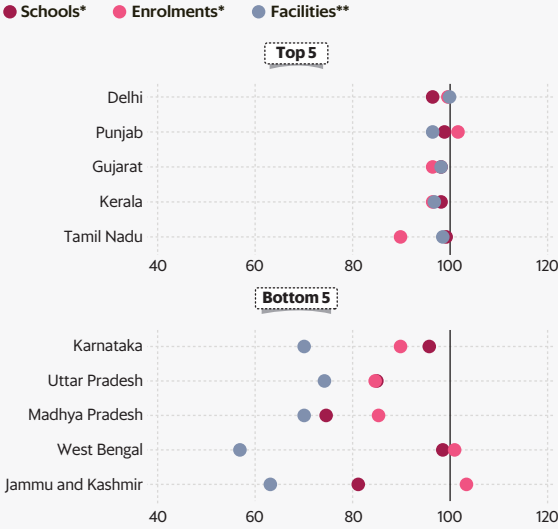


*Refers to budgeted figures.

Source: Unified District Information System for Education Plus reports, Reserve Bank of India, States' demand for grants, 16th Finance Commission, Mint calculations

West Bengal and J&K enrolled more students despite low scores on facilities

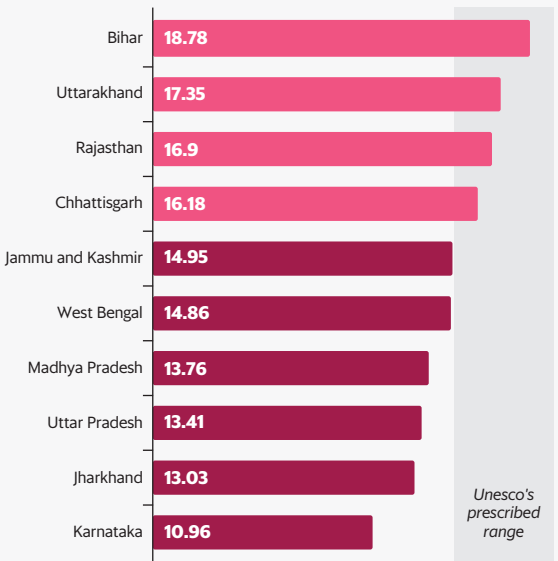
How top five and bottom five states fare on the following, 2025-26



*Refers to the number of government and government-aided schools and enrolment levels relative to 2018-19. **Refers to the average share of schools having access to six facilities: electricity, drinking water, toilets, library, computers and the internet.

Among states with low scores, only four states have higher spending on education

Spending on education as % of total expenditure*, bottom 10 states**



*Average for 2018-19 to 2025-26.

**States that have the lowest overall composite score.

Nearly 84,000 government and government-aided schools have shut down across India, and student enrolment has declined by nearly 15 million since 2018-19. Access to basic facilities like electricity, toilets, internet, and computers remains limited in several states, painting a bleak picture of the public education system in the country.

A *Mint* analysis of government and government-aided school data in 21 states and Union territories with over 10 million population on eight indicators—school closure, decline in enrolment, and access to electricity, drinking water, toilets, library, computers and the internet—shows Jammu and Kashmir, West Bengal, Madhya Pradesh, Uttar Pradesh, Karnataka, Rajasthan, Jharkhand, Bihar, Uttarakhand, and Chhattisgarh among the worst performing states.

School enrolment has declined much faster in states with average or poor facilities than in states with better amenities. Only a handful of states, such as Bihar and Uttarakhand, are spending over 15% of their budgets on education, while there are concerns about the shrinking space for education and other important areas as cash transfers take larger share of the spending pie.

Experts say long-standing issues in the public education system—from a shift towards private schools to inadequate facilities and poor learning outcomes—can be addressed by channelling more funds towards education. However, the “priorities are wonky”, said Anil Swarup, former school education secretary.

“All these issues can be addressed, but usually a politician is at best interested only in tomorrow, not what happens five years down the line. So they would rather give 10,000 rupees to a family to win elections and spend crores on publicity and statues instead of investing in education,” Swarup added.

STATE-WISE PERFORMANCE

States display varying performance on different indicators.

For example: Andhra Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh, Uttar Pradesh, Bihar and Uttarakhand are among the states that have seen the highest decline in enrolment in government and government-aided schools. In absolute terms, many of these states have seen a sharper fall in school enrolment than the decline in the population of school-going children aged 3-17 years, signalling that demographic change was not the only factor responsible for the decline in numbers.

When it comes to basic facilities, Rajasthan, Karnataka, Madhya Pradesh, Jammu and Kashmir, and West Bengal are among the worst-performing. To ascertain a more comprehensive picture, Mint calculated a weighted composite score out of 100 based on eight indicators related to government and government-aided schools: change in number of schools in 2025-26 relative to 2018-19 (weight: 17.39%), change in enrolment relative to 2018-19 (weight: 17.39%), and share of schools having access to facilities like electricity, drinking water and toilet (weight: 13.04% each) and library, computer and internet (weight: 8.7% each).

Delhi, Punjab, Gujarat, Kerala and Tamil Nadu stand out with the highest score, while Jammu and Kashmir, West Bengal, Madhya Pradesh, Uttar Pradesh, and Karnataka emerge poorly. The story, however, is more nuanced than what the composite scores indicate, with some outliers also. For example, both Jammu and Kashmir and West Bengal,

despite ranking among the worst, managed to lift school enrolment (at 103.4% and 100.8% relative to their 2018-19 figures). Madhya Pradesh, with 99.6% of schools having access to toilets, is ahead of 13 of the 21 states and UTs, while Karnataka, with 100% of schools having access to drinking water, tops the list on this front along with some other states.

FACILITIES AND ENROLMENT

One of the main criticisms of the public education system is that a lack of proper facilities has been pushing children towards private schools or out of the system.

An analysis of school enrolment relative to 2018-19 and access to facilities shows that the top five states that have better facilities have lost fewer students compared to rest. If there were 100 students enrolled in 2018-19 in the top five performing states—Delhi, Gujarat, Kerala, Punjab and Tamil Nadu—there were 95 in 2025-26.

When it comes to other states, the figure stands at 89. While this fall in enrolment has happened at all levels, lack of proper facilities may be linked to the decline in enrolment numbers, notwithstanding some outlier states like West Bengal and Jammu and Kashmir.

ELECTIONS OVER EDUCATION?

Indian states have spent 13-14% of their budgets on education on an aggregate basis in the last few years, data from the Reserve Bank of India showed. This falls short of the 15-20% prescribed by the United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization (Unesco).

More worryingly, this share has declined from 16% or more recorded consecutively between 2010-11 and 2014-15.

Among the states that fare poorly on the indicators mentioned above, Bihar (18.7%), Uttarakhand (17.4%), Rajasthan (16.9%), and Chhattisgarh (16.2%) are the only ones that have, on average since 2018-19, spent more than 15% of their budgets. This is reflected in a higher number of schools in Bihar (up 5.2% from 2018-19), Rajasthan (up 3.5%), and Chhattisgarh (up 0.3%). Maharashtra, which is an average performer overall but spent over 15.4% of its budget on education during the period, also saw a 0.6% rise in schools. Beyond the varying degree of spending on education among states and below-the-mark aggregate spending on education, shrinking space for such spending in recent years, mainly due to cash transfers as election doles, has also been a source of big worry.

At least 12-14 states and UTs have announced some form of cash transfers over the last few election cycles. Data on sectoral shares of the subsidies and transfers in the states' total revenue expenditure in the 16th Finance Commission report shows that the share of cash transfers has jumped from just 3% in 2018-19 to 20% in 2025-26. At the same time, the share of subsidies and transfers on health, education and housing has declined from 13% to 11%.

The report noted that expansion of subsidies and cash and in-kind transfers, if driven by populism, may crowd out other high-priority expenditures such as on education and health.

(This is the second part of a two-part series on India's government schools. The first part featured all-India trends on government schools, enrolment, facilities and learning outcomes. Read the first part here: <https://bit.ly/4uuuwpB3>)

Thursday, August 13, 2026

mint

livemint.com



Tiger exits TVF with valuation cut as OTT sector slows ▶ P3



Chinese carmakers' global push aids Indian suppliers ▶ P7

SENSEX 77,966.38 ↓ 187.87 NIFTY 24,435.95 ↓ 35.75 DOLLAR ₹95.33 ↓ ₹0.03 EURO ₹109.97 ↑ ₹0.14 OIL \$88.16 ↓ \$0.37 POUND ₹128.82 ↑ ₹0.07

Chandra to quit Tata Sons as efforts to resolve rift falter

Development follows long standoff over loss-making businesses' performance, roadmap

Varun Sood & Satish John
BENGALURU/MUMBAI

Natarajan Chandrasekaran's decision to step down as Tata Sons chairman and not seek another term followed a months-long standoff with Tata Trusts chairman Noel Tata over the performance and strategic direction of some of the group's new businesses, according to people familiar with the matter.

The decision came six days before the Tata Sons annual general meeting, scheduled for 18 August, and caught Noel Tata and most of the Tata Trusts trustees off-guard, two executives aware of the development said.

Chandrasekaran, who was first appointed chairman of Tata Sons in February 2017 and began a second five-year term in 2022, announced on Wednesday that he would not seek an extension beyond the end of his current term on 20 February 2027.

A senior Tata Group executive termed the resignation "irresponsible". "You were part of the Nomination and Remuneration Committee, and you did not start the succession planning exercise. The Tata Group has stood by you for the last nine years. And days before the shareholder meeting, the senior leader decides to put in his papers."

An email sent to Tata Sons went

EXIT MODE



LOG OUT

MOVE came six days before the Tata Sons annual general meeting

CHANDRA became Tata Sons chair in Feb 2017, 2nd term in 2022

EXTENSION stalled after Noel Tata sought a clear new biz roadmap

unanswered.

The decision followed an unresolved impasse over his reappointment. Tata Trusts had agreed in July 2025 to recommend a fresh five-year term for Chandrasekaran. The recommendation was subsequently taken up by the Tata Sons board on 24 February.

However, the proposal was not carried through after Noel Tata sought a clear roadmap for the performance of some of the new businesses launched under Chandrasekaran's watch, including e-commerce, aviation and semiconductors, according to a person familiar with the matter.

In his resignation letter, Chandrasekaran did not name Noel Tata, but said his decision not to seek another term was linked to the reappointment proposal.

"My current tenure as the Chairman of Tata Sons comes to an end on Feb 20, 2027. Sir Dorabji Tata Trust and Sir Ratan Tata Trust had unanimously resolved and recommended the extension of my next term for a period of five years, which was recorded and recommended by the Tata Sons Nomination and Remuneration Committee and the Board," Chandrasekaran wrote.

"Subsequently, the resolution was tabled in the Tata Sons Board on Feb 24, 2026. However, the proposal was not carried through because one of the Board Members did not support it, and in the absence of unanimous support, I chose to defer the decision," he said.

The Tata Sons board comprises Chandrasekaran, Noel Tata, TVS Motor Co. chairman emeritus Venu Srinivasan, Tata Group chief financial officer Saurabh Agrawal, and independent direct-

TURN TO PAGE 8

Tata's group market cap tripled under Chandra's watch >P8
A rift that ended Chandra's tenure as Tata Sons chairman >P8

Performance check

Challenges mounted during Chandra's second term.

N. CHANDRASEKARAN'S REPORT CARD

How the listed companies of the Tata Group fared under the outgoing chairperson's tenure (in ₹ trillion)

Revenue Profit Market Capitalization

FY17	0.40	5.94	8.38
FY22	0.76	8.46	23.16
FY26	1.73	12.09	24.04

Source: Bloomberg, Mint calculations

SATISH KUMAR/MINT

Two tenures, two different stories

Nehal Chaliawala
nehal.chaliawala@livemint.com
MUMBAI

Natarajan Chandrasekaran's term as chairman of Tata Sons has been a tale of two halves, with the Tata Group delivering a robust performance during his first term, and external challenges and the underperformance of private businesses catching up with India's largest conglomerate in the second.

During his first five-year term which ended in February 2022, Tata Group marquee companies such as Tata Consultancy Services (TCS) and Tata Steel delivered strong financial returns, suc-

cessfully tiding over the Covid-19 pandemic.

TCS continued to deliver record profits each year, maintaining its pole position in India's technology services sector.

Tata Steel delivered its highest-ever profit in fiscal year 2022 (FY22), overtaking even TCS, the group's biggest cash generator.

Tata Motors scripted a historic turnaround, rising from being a fringe player to finding a podium place on India's car sales charts in subsequent years.

Even within private businesses, the Tata Group made early inroads into e-com-

TURN TO PAGE 6

FULL STORY ON PAGE 8

DON'T MISS

Retail inflation rises to 4.45%
Retail inflation rose to 4.45% in July, led by higher food and fuel prices, surpassing RBI's 4% midpoint target for the second successive month since January 2025. >P2

BofA buys 49.9% in Jio Credit
Bank of America Corp will buy up to 49.9% in Jio Credit Ltd, the wholly-owned lending subsidiary of Jio Financial Services Ltd, for \$1.9 billion, the companies said. >P6

Tata Motors CV Q1 profit up 83%
Tata Motors Ltd posted solid revenue and profit growth in Q1 on the back of strong domestic demand, overcoming high fuel prices triggered by the West Asia war. >P5

Airtel scraps base plan, tariffs to rise

Jatin Grover
jatin.grover@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

A year after the last major pricing revision, indirect tariff hikes have returned to the Indian telecom market, driven by Bharti Airtel. The Sunil Bharti Mittal-led carrier has removed its entry-level ₹299 monthly prepaid plan that offered 1 gigabyte (GB) of data per day. To get a daily data allowance for 28 days, subscribers must now upgrade to the ₹349 plan, marking a ₹50 (16.7%) increase for an offering that includes

1.5GB of daily data and unlimited 5G access. Separately, Airtel also removed its ₹319 (30-day), ₹579, ₹619, and ₹649 prepaid plans. The development comes at a time when analysts had said that the only way for telcos to improve average revenue per user (ARPU)—a key telecom metric—would be to increase tariffs at regular intervals. Industry analysts and company insiders attribute Airtel's move primarily to shifting consumer habits, with users increasingly migrating to high-

TURN TO PAGE 9

PSU lenders sit on ECB fence

Subhana Shaikh
subhana.shaikh@livemint.com
MUMBAI

The Reserve Bank of India's (RBI's) concessional hedging window was expected to make overseas borrowing an attractive option for public sector companies. Seventy days on, the advantage is already wearing thin. Higher US Treasury yields and a rush of Indian banks into the dollar market have narrowed the cost gap with domestic bonds to just 8-10 basis points (bps), leaving public sector non-banking financial companies (NBFCs)

weighing whether to borrow overseas now, wait for better rates, or simply stay home, two PSUs and two merchant bankers said.

The squeeze is coming from both sides. US Treasury yields have climbed, while increased issuance by Indian banks raising dollars to fund foreign-currency non-resident (FCNR) deposits has pushed spreads higher, making dollar borrowing less lucrative for the government-run non-banks.

"The spread has gone up because of supply. When there

TURN TO PAGE 9

Big brands strike trails in new pockets

Varuni Khosla
varuni.k@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

British cookie brand Ben's Cookies could have chosen Khan Market, Delhi's best-known and busiest retail destination, for its first city store. Instead, it opened in June at Meherchand Market on Lodhi Road, a compact retail lane known more for designer and fashion labels than footfall. A larger shift is playing out across India's urban cities: bigger companies are choosing "city stores" over one big destination bet, some of them staying inside malls, some stepping outside onto less frequented high streets and residential lanes wherever allowed, while some moving into new retail pockets altogether around fresh developer projects. The common thread isn't the address, it's proximity, walkability and repeat consumption.



A shift is playing out across India's urban cities: bigger companies are choosing "city stores" over one big destination bet. ISTOCKPHOTO

Rising rents, urban India's dense catchments and difficult commutes are reshaping consumer behaviour, forcing retailers, including food and beverage brands, to rethink where and how they operate. Sanskriti Gupta of Ben's Cookies India said the brand is looking at premium high streets and neighbourhood catchments with a strong con-

sumer fit and footfall. For takeaway-led formats, such locations also offer convenience and allow brands to become part of consumers' everyday routines.

Swedish retailer Ikea, which typically operates one or two flagship stores in a city carrying its full range, is now adding smaller micro-market formats tailored to each cluster's "life at

home" needs, with a more limited product range and scaled-down room sets. In July, it opened a smaller format store in Delhi's DLF Avenue mall.

Its strategy is localized too. A Mumbai roomset, for instance, is built around homes closer to 500 square feet with multi-functional furniture such as sofa-cum-beds, quite different from what a South Delhi or West Delhi customer would see.

"We even know that a South Delhi home is very different from a West Delhi home. Same for a Mumbai, SoBo home," said Pooja Grover, country manager, Ikea India Pvt. Ltd.

Mumbai has its own version of the trend. Bootstrapped cafe chain Boojee Cafe, for instance, has shunned traditional commercial markets for residential lanes in Bandra West, with outlets near Carter Road and Perry

TURN TO PAGE 6

AXIS MAX

LIFE INSURANCE

APNO KE SAPNO KA BHAROSA AAP,

AAPKA LIFELONG BHAROSA HUM.

For yourself, for your family, **BHAROSA TUM HO**

START INVESTING TODAY FOR A HAPPY RETIREMENT TOMORROW

Axis Max Life Pension Plan

Or Contact an Axis Max Life Insurance Expert

Scan the QR code to buy Axis Max Life Pension Plan

The Brand Ambassadors (if depicted herein), have endorsed only the Axis Max Life Insurance Products and are not in any manner endorsing Axis Bank Limited and do not have any kind of association or relationship with Axis Bank Limited. Purchase by a bank's customer of any insurance product is purely voluntary and is not linked to the availing of any other facility from the bank. The visuals have been generated partially or fully using Artificial Intelligence (AI) and are not created by humans. Axis Max Life Insurance Limited (formerly known as Max Life Insurance Company Limited) is a Joint Venture between Max Financial Services Limited and Axis Bank Limited. Registered Office Address : Plot no. 90-C, Sector-18, Urban Estate, Gurugram, Haryana - 122015. CIN: U74899HR2000PLC143012 You can call us on our Customer Helpline No. 1860 120 5577. Website: <https://www.axismaxlife.com>

ARN: Axis Max Life/FCB/Brand/Retirement Print Ad/August 2026

BEWARE OF SPURIOUS / FRAUD PHONE CALLS!

- IRDAI or its officials do not involve in activities like selling insurance policies, announcing bonus or investments of premiums.
- Public receiving such phone calls are requested to lodge a police complaint

IRDAI Regn. No. 104



MINT SHORTS

FCRA Bill sent to JPC amid opposition protests

New Delhi: The Lok Sabha on Wednesday passed a motion to refer the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Amendment (FCRA) Bill, 2026, to a 31-member joint committee of Parliament for further scrutiny, amid strong opposition protests and demands for its withdrawal. The motion, moved by Minister of State for Home Nityanand Rai, provides for a committee comprising 21 members from the Lok Sabha and 10 from the Rajya Sabha. **PTI**

RBI proposes internal ceilings on small borrowers' loan rates



Mumbai: The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) proposed changes to how banks and non-banks calculate interest rates, saying that lenders should cap costs for small loans taken by borrowers and microfinance customers. It proposed that lenders put a ceiling on the annual percentage rate on microfinance loans and small value loans and ensure that they are not usurious. **SHAYAN GHOSH**

India plans insurance reforms to rein in healthcare costs

Mumbai: India is weighing wide-ranging reforms of health insurance, from benchmarked treatment rates to a nationwide claims exchange, as it looks to boost transparency in a struggle to hold down some of the highest medical inflation in Asia, two persons informed of the matter said. Reform recommendations are expected by year-end from a panel of regulators, industry leaders, hospitals and CII, the persons added. **REUTERS**

MMDA amendment Bill passes lower house without debate



New Delhi: The Lok Sabha on Wednesday passed the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026 without debate. The Bill seeks to restrict states from levying additional tax on mineral rights. It also seeks to give the Centre control over regulation of mineral-bearing lands having mineral contents in accordance with the parameters prescribed under the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Act. **PTI**

HPCL, MRPL seek up to six million barrels of crude

Singapore/New Delhi: State-run refiners Hindustan Petroleum Corp. and Mangalore Refinery and Petrochemicals Ltd are seeking up to a combined 6 million barrels of oil through spot tenders, documents show. HPCL plans to import up to four million barrels of crude for delivery in September and October, and MRPL is seeking up to 2 million barrels for 10-20 October, the documents show. **REUTERS**

Growing RE, transmission capacity gap a key credit risk: Ind-Ra

New Delhi: India Ratings and Research (Ind-Ra) on Wednesday said the growing gap between renewable energy (RE) commissioning and transmission readiness is emerging as a key credit risk for the sector. About 84GW of the 196GW RE pipeline till FY32 faces delays in general network access operationalization, highlighting a persistent transmission execution gap, it said in a statement. **PTI**

Gold hallmarking may soon get 'sold' tag to curb theft

A reused hallmark code would flag a piece of jewellery as already sold, helping curb theft.

Dhirendra Kumar
dhirendra.kumar@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

The Centre is planning a system to curb the sale of stolen gold jewellery by marking each piece as "sold" against its unique six-digit Hallmark Unique Identification (HUID) number after a transaction, two people directly involved in the process said.

The move would make it harder for jewellers to reuse the same HUID on another piece. If an HUID already marked "sold" is subsequently entered into the system for another article, it would flag that the item has already been sold, the people said.

The proposal is significant for India, the world's largest gold jewellery market, where snatching and theft are rampant. India's gems and jewellery market was valued at about \$85 billion in January 2026 and is projected to reach \$130 billion by 2030, according to the India Brand Equity Foundation.

According to Iera Research, cited in an Assocham report released in March 2026, organized jewellery retailers accounted for 16% of India's gold jewellery retail market in FY25, while the unorganized segment accounted for 84%.

"The plan is at the discussion stage, and the proposal is to initially make it mandatory in urban areas for organized



At present, jewellers have to inscribe the Hallmark Unique Identification number and weight on each hallmarked gold article. **REUTERS**

retailers, with the requirement eventually being extended to rural areas and the unorganised sector," said the first of the two persons cited above.

Queries sent to spokespersons of the department of consumer affairs, Tanishq, Indriya, Malabar Gold & Diamonds, Kalyan Jewellers and P.P. Jewellers remained unanswered until press time.

At present, jewellers have to inscribe the Hallmark Unique Identification number and weight on each hallmarked gold article.

Retailers also have to maintain records of hallmarked articles and keep

photographs of the HUID in their systems. Consumers can check the authenticity of the jewellery by entering its HUID number on the BIS Care app.

Under Section 29 of the BIS Act, 2016, misuse of the hallmark can attract imprisonment of up to one year or a fine of at least ₹1 lakh, which can be up to five times the value of the goods involved, or both. The Bureau of Indian Standards (BIS) can also cancel a jeweller's registration for unfair practices amounting to misuse of the hallmark.

"It could also help prevent the resale

of stolen or unauthorized gold items. A retailer accepting an old gold article for resale could check its HUID and transaction records against the invoice. If the HUID is already marked as sold to another consumer, it could raise a red flag and prompt the retailer to verify the source of the gold," said the second person.

"This will also help prevent the reuse of HUIDs, as each HUID will be marked as 'sold' after a transaction. If the same HUID is subsequently used on another article, the system could flag it as an already-sold item," this person said.

"The biggest concern for the industry is to keep a check on jewellers offering gold jewellery at zero per cent making charges, which is not commercially viable given the costs involved and the gold wastage during manufacturing. The government should focus on curbing such malpractices rather than imposing additional compliance burdens on genuine and honest jewellers," said Anil Talwar, managing partner, Talwarsons Jewellers, a Chandigarh-based BIS-certified jeweller and former All India co-chairman of FICCI Gems Committee.

The proposed system, however, could raise operational costs, especially when changes to a selected article alter its weight or specifications, a senior retail executive said.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

\$85 bn
India's gems and jewellery market as of January 2026

\$130 bn
Likely size of India's gems and jewellery market in 2030

Oil reserves planned at Bikaner and Bina

Rituraj Baruah
rituraj.baruah@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

Amid energy-security concerns, the Centre is planning two new strategic petroleum reserves (SPRs) at Bikaner in Rajasthan and Bina in Madhya Pradesh, as the West Asia conflict heightens the risk of crude-oil supply disruptions.

Feasibility studies for Bikaner have been completed and are being finalized, while the pre-feasibility study for Bina has concluded and a detailed feasibility report is set to begin, the ministry of petroleum and natural gas told a parliamentary standing committee.

The stakes are high for an economy that imports about 90% of its oil. A \$1 increase in crude prices, sustained for a year, can raise India's annual import bill by ₹18,000 crore, with implications for inflation, growth and the external sec-

tor. India's crude oil import bill surged 60% to \$49.8 billion in the June quarter (Q1FY27), even as volumes fell to 60 million tonnes from 62.6 million tonnes a year earlier, as per government data. The world's third-largest oil importer spent about \$31 billion on crude a year earlier.

"The Government also continuously evaluates new sites and expansion opportunities for augmenting crude oil and

petroleum product storage capacity, based on technical, commercial, and strategic considerations. Two more new SPR projects are under consideration, at Bikaner and Bina. Feasibility studies for the Bikaner caverns have been completed...while the pre-feasibility study for the Bina caverns has also concluded," the ministry said, as quoted by the parliamentary panel's report submitted on Wednesday.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

Subhash Narayan
subhash.narayan@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

India's retail inflation accelerated to 4.45% in July, led by higher food and fuel prices, surpassing the Reserve Bank of India's 4% midpoint target for the second successive month since January 2025, according to provisional data released by the ministry of statistics and programme implementation on Wednesday.

Inflation, measured by the Consumer Price Index (CPI), marginally exceeded the median estimate of 4.4% forecast by 20 economists in a *Mint* poll, as the full impact of petrol and diesel price hikes and firmer food prices came into effect.

Food inflation, a key constituent of the CPI, stood at 5.52% in July, up from 5.32% in June, 4.78% in May and 4.20% in April.

Although inflation remains within RBI's tolerance range of 2-6%, a further rise in prices may push the central bank to increase policy rates, which could suppress growth in the coming quarters.

Earlier this month, the RBI's



Although inflation remains within the tolerance range of 2-6%, a further rise in prices may push RBI to increase policy rates. **AP**

Monetary Policy Committee revised its FY27 inflation projection lower to 5% from 5.1%, but cited risks from an unexpected below-normal monsoon amid El Niño conditions, high and volatile energy prices, and possible second-round effects from elevated input costs. These factors could push up headline inflation in the coming months, with the peak expected in Q3FY27.

Food inflation, a key CPI factor, stood at 5.52% in July, up from 5.32% in June, 4.78% in May and 4.20% in April

"We see higher inflation potential in future given the state of monsoon and area under cultivation. While monsoon has recovered substantially in July, there has been news of crop damage due to excess rains," said Madan Sabnavis, chief economist, Bank of Baroda.

"This, combined with a longer cropping period and hence harvest, will push up prices of pulses in particular. Global prices of edible oils are also

high, which is being felt in domestic markets."

Silver, gold, diamond and platinum jewellery, as well as vegetables such as onion, ginger, and garlic were among the items that had the strongest inflationary pressure. Potato, peas, tomato, ladies finger and car and jeep were the top items with low-all-India inflation, the data showed.

"Core inflation, excluding food and fuel, is estimated near 4%, kept elevated by gold and silver prices amid geopolitical risk aversion and firm crude-linked transport costs," said Rajeev Sharan, head of research, Brickwork Ratings. "For Q2FY27, we expect headline inflation to average 4.5-4.7%, with a mild uptick likely in September as base effects turn less favourable. Going forward, food will remain the key swing factor amid uneven monsoon and El Niño-related uncertainty."

Inflation was the highest in Andhra, Telangana, Tamil Nadu and Karnataka as well as Madhya Pradesh, Odisha and Ladakh. It was the lowest in Delhi, Mizoram, Tripura, Meghalaya, and Nagaland.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

Centre allows renewable developers to cut tariffs after winning tenders

Rituraj Baruah
rituraj.baruah@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

Renewable energy developers can now voluntarily cut tariffs after winning a tender, a move that could help clear about 40GW of unsigned power purchase agreements (PPAs) without reopening the original bids.

The ministry of new and renewable energy (MNRE), in a communication dated 31 July, said renewable energy implementation agencies (REIAs), including Solar Energy Corp. of India Ltd (Seci), NTPC Ltd, SJVN Ltd

and NHPC Ltd, can accept a lower tariff offered by a successful bidder, provided the developer offers the cut on its own and is not asked or pressured to do so.

The clarification could give REIAs a way to make stuck projects more acceptable to power distribution companies (discoms), potentially allowing PPAs to be signed without changing the terms or configuration of the original bids.

The move comes as standalone renewable energy projects face a large backlog of unsigned PPAs, while discoms are signing expensive contracts to procure thermal



The Centre's move could help clear about 40GW of unsigned PPAs without reopening the original bids. **REUTERS**

power. Queries emailed to the MNRE remained unanswered until press time.

In April, MNRE had advised REIAs to discourage post-tender negotiations with developers or end procurers to modify

discovered tariffs. Its 31 July cited a 2022 Central Electricity Regulatory Commission observation (CERC) that voluntary reduction in the discovered tariff does not violate the rules.

The ministry, in its latest communication, said it had received a representation seeking clarification on whether the earlier directive applied when a successful bidder itself offered to reduce the discovered tariff after completion of the bidding process.

"It is further clarified that nothing contained in the aforesaid communication dated 06.04.2026 shall pre-

clude a successful bidder from voluntarily offering a reduction in the discovered tariff, suo moto, on its own volition, provided that such reduction is not pursuant to any request, solicitation, negotiation, inducement or direction from the REIA/procuring entity. Such voluntary and unsolicited tariff reduction may be accepted by the concerned REIA and shall not be construed as post-tender tariff negotiation," the communication, reviewed by *Mint*, showed.

The April directive barred REIAs or procuring entities from seeking, negotiating or

making the execution of project agreements conditional on a lower tariff after the tender. "Accordingly, REIAs/procuring entities shall not seek, solicit, negotiate, induce, insist upon, or make execution of the Letter of Award (LoA), Power Purchase Agreement (PPA), Power Sale Agreement (PSA), or allocation of capacity contingent upon any reduction in the discovered tariff," it said.

The provision could help developers cut prices to find buyers if later tenders offer lower tariffs, an official said.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

CORRECTIONS AND CLARIFICATIONS

Mint welcomes comments, suggestions or complaints about errors.

Readers can alert the newsroom to any errors in the paper by emailing us, with your full name and address to feedback@livemint.com.

It is our policy to promptly respond to all complaints. Readers dissatisfied with the response or concerned about *Mint's* journalistic integrity may write directly to the editor by sending an email to asktheditor@livemint.com

Mint's journalistic Code of Conduct that governs our newsroom is available at www.livemint.com



Boldfit looks to raise \$80-100 mn from PE funds

Priyamvada C. & Sneha Shah
MUMBAI

Bling Brands Pvt Ltd, which operates direct-to-consumer fitness brand Boldfit, has initiated a process to raise \$80-100 million from private equity funds, three people familiar with the matter said.

"Several funds including Sofina, Verlinvest and Venturi Partners are expected to be sounded out to gauge their interest in the company," the first person said. While Venturi typically writes smaller cheques in the range of \$15-40 million, it can take part in larger rounds through co-investments, the person said.

"Other investors such as Motilal Oswal's private equity arm and Kedaara Capital are also expected to be tapped as a part of the process," the second person said. "The company is roughly seeking a valuation of about ₹3,000-4,000 crore based on forward-looking revenue multiples," the third person said.

The people added that Boldfit has mandated Aventus as an advisor to help with the process. All of them spoke on the condition of anonymity as the discussions are still private.

India's fitness economy has gained strong momentum in recent years across major urban areas and smaller towns. The industry is expected to grow at a CAGR of 15% from \$1.9 billion in 2024 to \$4.5 billion over the next four years, according to a report by Deloitte India and the Health & Fitness Association (HFA).

"Boldfit and the funds did



Boldfit is eyeing a potential ₹3,000-4,000 crore valuation.

not respond to *Mint's* requests for comment, while Aventus declined to comment."

Founded in 2019 by Pallav Bihani and Aashna Gupta, Boldfit designs, manufactures and sells products across fitness and sports categories, including equipment, sports shoes, sneakers and apparel.

The firm last raised ₹110 crore in a funding round led by Bessemer Venture Partners in 2024. It also counts KL Rahul and Sania Mirza as investors.

Its product portfolio spans sports such as swimming, yoga and trekking, with offerings including pull-up bars, resistance bands, lifting gear, running and walking shoes, and athleisure, among others.

Boldfit's operating revenue nearly doubled to ₹139.70 crore in FY25 from ₹73.71 crore a year ago. Its net profit widened to ₹16.81 crore from ₹15.71 crore in FY24, show filings sourced from the ministry of corporate affairs by Tofler. The firm is yet to file its financials for FY25 and FY26.

priyamvada.c@livemint.com
For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

OTT slowdown: Tiger Global exits TVF at lower valuation

The deal valued TVF at \$22 mn, nearly a quarter of its 2019 peak valuation of \$82 million

Mansi Verma
mansi.verma@livemint.com
MUMBAI

Pivate equity firm Tiger Global Management has fully exited Indian digital entertainment company The Viral Fever (TVF), creator of shows such as *Kota Factory* and *Panchayat*, in a transaction that valued the company at one-fourth of its 2019 peak valuation, three people close to the deal told *Mint*.

The private equity firm sold up to a 40% stake to investors, including Lighthouse India Fund-I, Frontier Globecap Ventures and LC Nueva Advisors LLP, in a funding round that valued the company at \$22 million, down from \$82 million in 2019.

The exit comes a decade after Tiger Global acquired a significant minority stake of roughly 25% in TVF's parent company, Contagious Online Media Network, through an initial \$10 million investment in 2016, followed by subsequent funding injections up to 2019. *Mint* reported at the time that TVF was valued at \$61 million in February 2016.

TVF and Lighthouse Canton declined to comment. *Mint's* queries emailed to Tiger Global went unanswered.

The transaction also comes as TVF announced three senior hires across its creative and corporate teams. The changes coincide with the departure of Shreyansh Pandey, head of TVF Originals, who is leaving after eleven years with the company to start an independent venture. Pandey is credited with TVF shows including *Kota Factory*, *Aspirants*, *Gullak*, and *Cubicles*.

This is when the over-the-top content industry has become more cautious about spending on original content as global platforms face pressure to improve profitability. At the same time, consolidation among streaming platforms and the emergence of new players



OTT platforms are tightening budgets for originals, affecting the likes of *Panchayat* maker TVF.

have made commissioning decisions slower and more selective.

Over the past two years, platforms such as SonyLIV and JioHotstar have also scaled back their spending on web series after a period of heavy investment, *Mint* reported in 2024.

The slowdown coincided with rising

shows to them, are feeling the heat.

TVF, founded in 2012 by Arunabh Kumar, last raised a Series D round in 2019 led by Tiger Global, BlackSoil, StartX, Venture Highway, and Naseba. A venture debt round followed in 2021, led by BlackSoil. TVF's revenue rose from ₹34.3 crore in 2020-21 to ₹182.4

VALUATION RESET

PE firm sold its 40% stake to Lighthouse India Fund-I, Frontier Globecap Ventures, LC Nueva Advisors

TIGER Global first invested \$10 million in TVF in 2016 for a roughly 25% stake in its parent company

THE exit follows a TVF leadership reshuffle, including its Originals head, Pandey's departure

TVF'S revenue grew to ₹182.4 cr in FY25, but net profit fell from its FY22 peak of ₹68.3 cr to ₹13 cr

competition among studios and production houses, which are competing for a smaller pool of original-content budgets. As major streaming platforms Netflix and Amazon Prime Video commission fewer shows, platforms such as TVF, which initially built their business around creating and licensing original

shows to them, are feeling the heat. TVF's revenue peaked at ₹68.3 crore in FY22, then fell to ₹13 crore in FY25, while the five-year compound annual growth rate remained positive at 17%, according to data from market intelligence platform Tracxn.

Tiger Global had first backed TVF after a string of successful web shows,

particularly *Kota Factory*, a five-episode satirical comedy about students aspiring to enter the prestigious Indian Institutes of Technology and the gruelling journey they undertake to get there.

TVF was a darling of media and advertisers in 2015-2017, when its parody videos of Bollywood actors, news anchors, and everyday family situations on YouTube were hugely popular.

It started out solely as a YouTube channel, competing with the likes of AIB and East India Comedy, producing comic sketches. It later started producing web shows cutting across genres such as drama and comedy, and spun off its productions to its TVF Play app as well.

TVF's YouTube channel currently has more than six million subscribers.

Kumar resigned in 2017 following a sexual harassment complaint from a former employee. A court acquitted Kumar, citing an unexplained delay in filing the complaint.

Zetwerk plans up to \$400-mn IPO by Sep

Bloomberg
feedback@livemint.com

Zetwerk Pvt, an Indian contract manufacturer, is preparing to file for an initial public offering that could raise as much as \$400 million, according to people familiar with the matter.

The Bengaluru-based firm, which confidentially filed for an IPO in March, may submit updated paperwork this week and is likely to begin investor meetings this month, targeting a launch as early as September, the people said, asking not to be identified because the information is private.

Zetwerk is working with Kotak Mahindra Capital Co., JM Financial Services Ltd, Aventus Capital Pvt and the Indian units of HSBC Holdings Plc, Morgan Stanley and Goldman Sachs Group Inc. to manage the share sale, they said.

Deliberations are ongoing and details including the size and timing of the IPO could change, they said. Representatives for Zetwerk and banks didn't immediately respond to requests for comment. Zetwerk last month received feedback from the regulator on the draft documents it filed in March. Under Indian rules, companies using the confidential filing route are required to make their paperwork public at least 21 days before launching an offering.

It would join a growing list of firms tapping India's IPO market, raising about \$7 billion so far this year. That follows a record \$22 billion fundraise in 2025, show data compiled by *Bloomberg*.

Zetwerk makes industrial products for utilities, renewable energy, consumer electronics and AI infrastructure.



CP PLUS
Intelligent Security Systems

ADITYA INFOTECH LIMITED

**SMART AI
CCTV
SOLUTIONS**



upar wala sab dekh raha hai

Registered Office: F-28, Okhla Industrial Area, Phase -1, New Delhi-110020, Delhi, India

Corporate Office: A-12, Sector 4, Noida-201301, Uttar Pradesh, India

Telephone: +91 120 4555 666, Corporate Identity Number: L74899DL1995LC066784, Website: www.adityagroup.com

**STATEMENT OF UNAUDITED FINANCIAL RESULTS
(STANDALONE & CONSOLIDATED) FOR THE
QUARTER ENDED JUNE 30, 2026**



The Board of Directors of the Company, at their meeting held on August 12, 2026, approved the Unaudited Financial Results (Standalone & Consolidated) of the Company for the Quarter ended June 30, 2026 ("Financial Results").

The Unaudited Financial Results along with the Limited Review Report, have been hosted on the Company's website – www.adityagroup.com, and on the websites of the Stock Exchanges – BSE Limited and National Stock Exchange of India Limited at www.bseindia.com and www.nseindia.com, respectively. The same can be accessed by scanning the QR Code.

Note: The above intimation is in accordance with Regulation 47(1), read with Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015.

For and on behalf of the Board
Aditya Infotech Limited
Sd/-

Aditya Khemka
Managing Director
DIN: 00514552

Place: Noida

Date: August 12, 2026



**Celebrating 4 years of being
India's favourite sedan**
Virtus now in Avocado Pearl*



GLOBAL INCAP 4 year Standard Warranty 4 year Road Side Assistance 3 Free Services Exchange through Certified Pre-Owned Additional Scrapage Benefits** Available across GeM, CSD & KPKB Call 1800 102 0909 volkswagen.co.in

Images are for representation purpose. The dark shade on the glass is due to the lighting effect. Features and accessories shown may not be part of the standard equipment and are subject to change without prior notice. The actual car colour may vary. *150 units only. **Labour charges free for service applicable on mileage of 1,000, 7,500 and 15,000 kilometers. ***Additional scrapage benefits of up to ₹20,000.

Authorised Dealers: **Volkswagen Bangalore North:** Thanisandra: 7032397999, 9606988828; **Volkswagen Bangalore North:** Hebbal: 7032397999, 9100995753; **Volkswagen City Center:** Richmond Road, 7032397999, 9281147546; **Volkswagen City Center:** Lalbagh Road: 7032397999, 9281096188; **Volkswagen City Store Bengaluru North:** Yelahanka: 7032397999, 9100666023; **Volkswagen Palace Cross:** 9686601249; **Volkswagen Palace Cross:** Mysore Road: 9686601249; **Volkswagen Palace Cross:** Rajajinagar (Sales Point): 9686601249; **Volkswagen Whitefield:** B. Narayanapura: 9900010727, 9900021210; **Volkswagen City Store Avalahalli:** 7022033509, 7022033511; **Volkswagen Bangalore South:** JP Nagar, 9952220000; **Talaghattapura:** 9148418222; **Volkswagen City Store:** Koramangala: 9952220000; **Volkswagen Bangalore:** Hosur Road: 9900091212, 9108089495; **CPO Outlet:** **Volkswagen Mysore Road:** 9686601249; **Volkswagen Tumkur:** Sira Main Road: 7032397999, 9100919214.



BSE Sensex			Nifty 50			Nifty 500			Nifty Next 50			Nifty 100			BSE 150 MidCap			BSE 250 SmallCap		
CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE		CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE		CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE		CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE		CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE		CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE		CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE	
77,966.35	-0.24		24,435.95	-0.15		23,672.45	-0.04		74,748.10	0.13		25,601.20	-0.09		17,266.44	-0.02		7,240.81	-0.27	
PREVIOUS CLOSE		OPEN	PREVIOUS CLOSE		OPEN	PREVIOUS CLOSE		OPEN	PREVIOUS CLOSE		OPEN	PREVIOUS CLOSE		OPEN	PREVIOUS CLOSE		OPEN	PREVIOUS CLOSE		OPEN
78,154.25		78,263.33	24,471.70		24,472.45	23,681.15		23,689.55	74,650.85		74,580.35	25,625.40		25,621.50	17,269.54		17,288.79	7,260.60		7,282.74
HIGH		LOW	HIGH		LOW	HIGH		LOW	HIGH		LOW	HIGH		LOW	HIGH		LOW	HIGH		LOW
78,263.33		77,497.93	24,473.30		24,265.95	23,690.05		23,526.20	74,759.40		74,130.25	25,622.20		25,419.80	17,290.93		17,197.48	7,282.81		7,232.53

Hope floats for Vodafone Idea

Ananya Roy
feedback@livemint.com

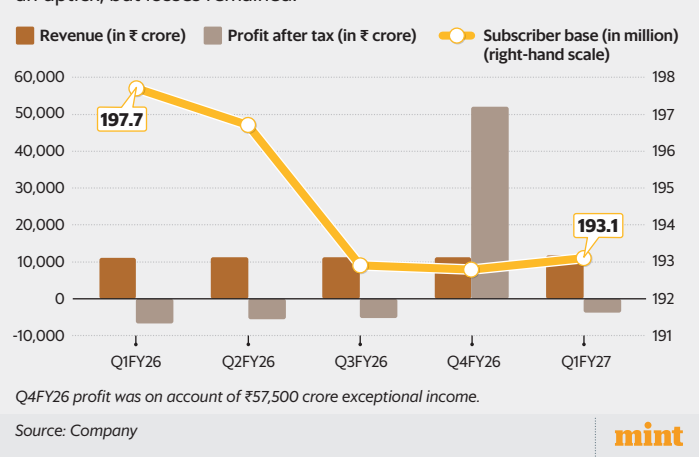
Vodafone Idea's June-quarter (Q1FY27) result signals a long-awaited turnaround may finally be taking shape, despite funding risks. Reversing years of customer losses, it added 0.3 million subscribers in Q1FY27, a first since the 2018 merger, taking its total subscriber base to 193 million.

Revenue grew 6% year-on-year to ₹11,689 crore, beating estimates. Ebitda rose 9% to ₹5,034 crore. Reported loss of ₹3,754 crore in Q1FY27 narrowed from ₹6,608 crore a year ago, but the quarter included an exceptional gain of ₹1,816 crore due to an increase in the value of Vodafone Group's shares. Adjusted for all exceptional items, the loss stood at ₹5,358 crore. Average revenue per user (Arpu) rose 1.7% sequentially and 7.3% year-on-year to ₹177. The management sees more room for Arpu growth; 2G to 4G migration can take Arpu to ₹230-240, while unlimited plans can add ₹30-35.

The stock rose 3.3% on Wednesday

Green shoots?

Vodafone Idea added subscribers in Q1FY27, revenue showed an uptick, but losses remained.



Q4FY26 profit was on account of ₹57,500 crore exceptional income.

Source: Company

PRATEEK KUMAR/MINT

day and has more than doubled over the past year to ₹13. Still, it remains far from its 2015 peak of ₹120. Adjusted gross revenue liability overhang and weak finances led to inadequate network investments, causing subscriber losses, which further weakened cash flows. Subscriber additions suggest the vicious

cycle is, at the very least, stabilizing. Postpaid subscriber base grew, and the machine-to-machine (M2M) connections doubled over last year. The management expects M2M traction to sustain on the back of its strong position in the connected car segment. However, while M2M growth can add subscribers, it is

expected to be Arpu-dilutive. Customer Arpu in Q1 was ₹195, while blended Arpu (including M2M) was ₹177. The loss of prepaid customers is also a concern.

As for capital expenditure—the elephant in the room—Vodafone reiterated its ₹45,000 crore network

investment plan over the next three years, with ₹9,000-crore orders already placed. But delayed funding can play spoilsport. It has secured ₹6,400 crore, including promoter support, while discussions continue for the balance debt raise. Funding remains the biggest swing factor for Vodafone Idea. "VIL has arrested subscriber losses and improved ARPU and churn, with focus now shifting to capex deployment and delayed debt fund raise. We tweak our FY27E/28E Ebitda by -2.6%/-0.8% as we push forward FY27 tariff hike by a quarter," said Nuvama Research. Funding will help it execute capex, and catch up on network quality. That will help

retain subscriber additions, benefit from future tariff hikes, and ultimately determine whether the Q1 recovery lasts.

Bharti Airtel's India wireless Arpu stood at ₹264 and subscriber base at 680 million in Q1FY27, while the same for Reliance Jio were at ₹216 and

530 million, respectively, both dwarfing Vodafone Idea's numbers. Also, Airtel and Jio's cash-flow generation support their capex plans, giving them far greater financial flexibility to invest in network quality and customer acquisition. Still, Vodafone Idea has guided for double-digit revenue growth and a tripling of cash Ebitda over the next three years. "VI's significant valuation premium (-26.6x Sep'28 pre-IND AS EV/EBITDA), compared to its larger and more profitable peer (-10.5x for Bharti India), caps the upside from potential benefits of an acceleration in network roll-out," notes Motilal Oswal Financial Services.

FUNDING PLAN

VODAFONE reiterated its ₹45,000 cr network investment plan over the next three years. IT has raised ₹6,400 crore, including promoter support, and is in talks for the balance debt

After Mahanadi, Coal India's SECL preps ₹10k-cr IPO

Agnidev Bhattacharya
agnidev.bhattacharya@livemint.com
MUMBAI

South Eastern Coalfields Ltd (SECL), a subsidiary of Coal India Ltd, has initiated the process of appointing investment banks for an initial public offering, according to a document reviewed by *Mint*.

SECL's proposed IPO, which is expected to be a mix of a fresh issue of shares and an offer for sale by the parent company, is likely to be worth around ₹8,000 crore to ₹10,000 crore, two people aware of the matter told *Mint*. The coal producer is seeking four to five bookrunning lead managers to structure and manage the public issue.

Coal India plans to divest up to 25% of its shareholding in the subsidiary over time, the document showed.

The initial tranche will comprise an offer for sale of at least 10% of Coal India's holdings alongside a potential fresh equity issuance of about 5% by SECL.

Prior to the offering, the company's equity shares, which carry a face value of ₹1,000 apiece, will be split into shares of a lower face value.

SECL is among the highest coal-producing subsidiary companies of Coal India. Its 61 coal mines are spread across Chhattisgarh and Madhya Pradesh. The mines are divided into three groups: Central India coalfields, Korba coalfields and Mand Raigarh Coalfields.

The company produced 176.2 million tonnes of coal in FY26, registering a growth of 5.26%.

SECL also operates a coal carbonization plant of Dankuni Coal Complex in West Bengal



SECL's 61 coal mines are spread across two states.

MINT

that was leased to it by Coal India. The plant produces coal gas, coke fines, coal fines, dehydrated tar and ammonium sulphates, among others.

Coal India did not immediately respond to *Mint*'s queries seeking comment on the planned IPO.

Mint reported on 4 August that Mahanadi Coalfields Ltd (MCL), another Coal India subsidiary, had appointed SBI Capital Markets, Axis Capital, IIFL Capital Services, IDBI Capital

Markets and Bank of Baroda Capital Markets as merchant bankers for its proposed IPO of about ₹10,000 crore.

"Both the IPO processes will run simultaneously, with SECL

expected to list a month or two after Mahanadi," one person said on condition of anonymity.

Coal India had approved preliminary plans to partially sell stakes in two of its largest subsidiaries—SECL and MCL—as part of its broader subsidiary listing strategy.

The listing plans followed an advisory from the ministry of coal, which asked Coal India to initiate concrete steps to facilitate the listing of its subsidiaries in the current financial year, *Mint* reported in December.

Manappuram leans on gold loans as other businesses fade

Harsha Jethmalani
harsha@livemint.com

After a tepid FY26, Manappuram Finance saw profitability pick up in the June quarter (Q1FY27), with gold loans doing the heavy lifting and compensating for muted growth in other businesses.

Consolidated assets under management (AUM) grew 57% year-on-year to ₹69,635 crore, while gold loan AUM nearly doubled to ₹57,006 crore. Gold loans contributed 82% to consolidated AUM in Q1FY27, against 65% a year ago.

Pricier gold and a gradual

shift towards formalized financing buoyed gold loan demand even in a seasonally weak Q1. Manappuram is targeting 25-30% growth in gold loans in FY27, while peer Muthoot Finance targets 15%.

Gold loan yield rose 60 basis points sequentially to 17.7% in Q1FY27, driven by corrective pricing actions, and may remain around 18%.

Manappuram is aggressively strengthening gold lending. It plans to open 500 new gold loan branches in FY27 after the Reserve Bank of India removed the requirement of prior approvals.

While Manappuram has a

Shining bright

Manappuram Finance's gold loan business saw robust improvement in Q1FY27, driving consolidated AUM growth.



AUM is assets under management.

Source: Company, Nirmal Bang Institutional Equities Research

PRATEEK KUMAR/MINT

more diversified lending portfolio than Muthoot, it is prioritizing asset quality and portfolio stabilization in non-gold

lending segments. Its long-term strategy is to keep 75-80% of consolidated AUM in gold loans, while capping

microfinance exposure at 8-10%, compared with around 7% currently. Manappuram has suspended vehicle finance as it focuses on collections amid asset quality concerns.

Manappuram's new MD and CEO Ashish Singh, who takes over on 1 January, faces an uphill task of improving profitability following a sharp moderation in gold loan yields, said HDFC Securities. It cautions that loan growth could decelerate significantly due to consolidation in gold prices, elevated competitive intensity and new regulations on loan-to-value norms.

So far in CY26, Manappu-

ram's stock is up 13%, compared with a 24% decline in Muthoot. "This divergence could be due to margin outlook; Manappuram's calculated NIM bottomed out last quarter and improved by 50bps sequentially to 10%, while Muthoot saw 300bps contraction," said Akshat Agrawal, analyst at Nirmal Bang Institutional Equities.

Manappuram's RoA and RoE improved to 3.2% and 13.6%, respectively, in Q1FY27 from 2.8% and 11% in FY26. However, that is largely captured in the current valuation, limiting the scope for further rerating, he added.

Zee asks SAT to let it sell MF investments to fund daily ops

Yash Tiwari & Apoorva Ajith
MUMBAI

Zee Entertainment Enterprises Ltd on Wednesday asked the Securities Appellate Tribunal (SAT) to lift the Securities and Exchange Board of India's (Sebi's) market-access ban, saying it needs to sell about ₹1,200 crore of liquid mutual fund investments to fund day-to-day operations.

Responding to the tribunal's question on why the company wanted to sell the investments, Zee's counsel said the funds would be used mainly for short-term business requirements: "For making films, paying people, creditors."

The plea comes as Zee challenges Sebi's 31 July order barring the company from accessing the securities market for two months. The order also restrained chief executive officer Punit Goenka and promoter Subhash Chandra from accessing the market for 12 months each.

SAT questioned Sebi on why Zee should be prevented from raising funds for two months if the proposed transaction could otherwise be completed after the ban expires. "If there is no illegality in raising the money after two months, and in the teeth of this order it is to be stopped in a securities market, what is the logic?" the tribunal asked.

Emailed queries to Sebi



Zee says it needs to sell about ₹1,200 cr of MF investments. Sebi argues the case involves violations by promoters.

REUTERS

remain unanswered.

A Zee spokesperson declined to comment, stating the matter is sub-judice.

Zee's counsel said the company was supposed to raise almost ₹3,100 crore, but the market-access ban had affected the fundraising as the share price had fallen. He said the fundraise would benefit public shareholders, who hold around 96% of the company.

Counsel appearing for Goenka separately alleged that Sebi's order had pushed down the

share price, meaning the fundraise would now take place at a lower valuation than originally finalised.

On 31 July, Zee's shareholders approved a ₹3,143.5-crore fundraising plan that would increase the promoter's stake to 23.79%, from around 4% currently.

rently. Zee shares on the NSE fell from ₹114.55 on 31 July to ₹98.10 on Wednesday.

Sebi has opposed Zee's plea, arguing that the matter involved serious violations by the company's promoters, who allegedly used properties of the listed company as security for loans taken by privately held promoter entities.

"A property owned by a listed company to cover security in respect of their private loans taken by their private companies," the regulator's counsel said.

The case stems from Sebi's findings in its 31 July final order that a property owned by Zee was allegedly used as security for loans taken by promoter-linked companies.

After hearing both sides, the tribunal reserved its order and asked Sebi to file its reply within six weeks.

yash.tiwari@livemint.com
For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

No foul play in closing auctions: Sebi chief

Apoorva Ajith
apoorva.ajith@livemint.com
MUMBAI

The Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) has so far not observed any wrongdoing during closing auction sessions (CAS) for stocks, a mechanism introduced to curb price manipulation and improve price discovery, chairman chief Tuhin Kanta Pandey said.

"We haven't seen it yet, but we are constantly checking our data. Mutual fund participation [in the closing auctions] was 5-7% earlier. Now it's almost 25%," Pandey said on Wednesday.

The closing auction session system debuted on 3 August for 208 derivative-traded stocks. On the first day of CAS, the NSE Nifty50 surged 1.6%, while the BSE Sensex gained just 0.7%. The Nifty's move was driven by a 200-point jump in the final two minutes of the order-closing period, leaving traders puzzled.

"We were behind in introducing CAS, all our counterparts have already done it. But whenever there is a change, it takes time to prepare the whole industry. This is not a black box where traders wouldn't know what is happening in the 15 minutes, CAS has indicative prices," said Pandey.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

PEs eye exit paths as IPO road lengthens

Agnidev Bhattacharya
agnidev.bhattacharya@livemint.com
MUMBAI

Private equity firms in India with mature, older-vintage assets are broadening their search for exit routes beyond the stock market, as a soft initial public offering (IPO) run prompts fund managers to explore secondary trades and deals between rival PE sponsors.

For PEs originally said to have explored initial public offerings, the strongest interest to explore alternate routes is currently in businesses where "earnings visibility and cash-flow generation are relatively strong—financial services, healthcare, consumer businesses, technology-enabled companies and select manufacturing and industrial platforms," said Prakash Bulusu, joint chief executive officer at Fairfax-backed investment banking firm IIFL Capital Services.

On 6 August, global private equity giant KKR announced the acquisition of the Indian hospital operations of Stockholm-based Medivoc AB for \$1.3 billion. The deal was said to have emerged as discussions to take the company public fell through, after the IPO had been planned since December.

Mint had also reported on 6 May that Chennai-based NBFC Veritas Finance Ltd, which is backed by the likes of Kedaara Capital and Norwest Venture Partners, was considering a largely secondary offer of up to \$100 million to offer exits to early investors, as vola-



Fund managers are using secondary transfers, sponsor-to-sponsor buyouts and continuation vehicles to return capital.

ISTOCKPHOTO

tile markets delayed its IPO plans.

While India's primary market activity seems to be finally picking up pace, the first half of the year has not played out in favour of private funds, which decided to use initial public offerings as exit routes this year.

Exits executed through IPOs declined 47% year-on-year to \$801 million across 12 transactions during the six months ended 30 June, according to data from EY and the Indian Private Equity & Venture Capital Association. Total exit values in the country fell 29% in the same period to \$9.4 billion. Of this, open-market sales generated \$4.1 billion, representing 44% of total exit value, while secondary trades recorded \$1 billion across 19 transactions during the same period.

The drop in public market proceeds coincides with capital deployed around the 2016-2021 so-called 'vintage years' reaching typical five-to-ten year holding period limits.

While alternate exit routes are becoming a more deliberate part of exit planning, "IPOs

will continue to remain relevant, particularly for quality assets," said Apurva Kanvinde, partner at M&A legal advisory firm Juris Corp. "But IPOs are closely tied to market windows, valuation expectations and investor appetite," he added.

With general partners (GPs) facing heightened pressure from limited partners to improve distributed-to-paid-in capital (DPI) ratios, fund managers are deploying secondary transfers, sponsor-to-sponsor buyouts, and continuation vehicles to return

IPO exits declined 47% to \$801 million across 12 transactions during the six months ended 30 June

capital to investors.

"DPI is an important factor, particularly for older vintages where sponsors have held assets for longer than originally envisaged," Bulusu said. "A secondary transaction can provide certainty of execution and immediate liquidity, whereas an IPO involves market timing, regulatory processes, investor demand and post-listing lock-ins."

In fact, *Mint* had reported on 13 April that over 10 active IPO mandates—irrespective of investor backing—had transitioned to this dual-track model, especially for deals in the ₹500-2,000 crore range.

Capital market lawyers that *Mint* spoke to also said that regulatory overhauls are enabling more flexibility for alternative transactions over unpredictable IPO exits.

"What's making this more than a market-appetite story is that 2026's regulatory overhaul is actively reshaping how lawyers structure exits," said Akshat Pande, managing partner at corporate legal advisory firm Alpha Partners. "A relaxed Press Note 3 on FDI eligibility, a Finance Act 2026 that puts trade sales, buybacks, and secondary (LP-to-LP or GP-led) transfers on distinct capital-gains regimes, and raised buy-back thresholds," he said, are making alternate exits even more lucrative.

IIFL's Bulusu said he expects to see more situations in which sponsors are willing to trade some potential IPO upside for greater certainty of execution and faster DPI, particularly for mature assets.

Why the Centre is against states taxing minerals

FROM FRONT FLAP

2 How are minerals taxed in India?

Before 1990, many states levied a cess on mineral production under their own laws, usually linked to the royalty, which is fixed by the Centre but collected by states. In 1989, the Supreme Court in the India Cements Ltd vs Government of Tamil Nadu case held that royalty is a tax and that states do not have the power to tax minerals, as such power is governed by the MMDR Act. In 1992, the Centre raised royalty to compensate states for revenue losses resulting from the court order. In 2004, the Supreme Court in the State of West Bengal vs Kesoram Industries Ltd case, held that royalty was not a tax and that states could tax minerals. Empowered by the new Supreme Court order, a few states, including Andhra Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh, and Chhattisgarh, began levying taxes on minerals.



3 How was the divergent view resolved?

The divergent opinions co-existed for years. Some states, such as the ones mentioned earlier, taxed the minerals, while others did not. It was only in 2011 that the issue was referred to a nine-judge Constitution Bench to decisively rule whether royalty was a tax and whether states had the power to tax minerals, or was it the prerogative of the Union government. The Constitution Bench, in July 2024, held that royalty was not a tax and states could tax minerals.

4 What has happened since?

For the cash-strapped states, the final top court order opened a new revenue stream. They enacted laws to tax minerals. Jharkhand introduced the Mineral Bearing Land Cess Act in 2024, levying a cess on iron ore (₹400/tonne), coal (₹250/tonne) and limestone (₹40/tonne). Tamil Nadu introduced its law in 2025 and imposed a levy of ₹160/tonne on limestone and ₹250/tonne on lignite, among others. Karnataka, too, introduced a Bill in 2024. It is awaiting the governor's assent. Andhra Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh, and Chhattisgarh continue to charge according to their earlier laws.

5 How will the new law help?

Some states, such as Tamil Nadu, have begun to see mineral taxes as a cash cow. For instance, its ₹160/tonne tax on limestone, a key raw material in cement production, has hurt manufacturers' competitiveness in the state, as royalties and taxes account for 50% of the mineral's value. Today, excessive fiscal burden risks slowing mineral extraction, hurting production of metals and other essential commodities, and eventually slowing economic growth. The new law seeks to ease the fiscal burden on the mining sector, improve its viability and make it attractive for investments.

BofA to buy up to 49.9% in Jio Credit for \$1.9 bn

Jio Financial's third global partnership values lending business at about \$3.8 bn

Samridhhi Mahar
samridhhi.mahar@livemint.com
MUMBAI

Global financial institution Bank of America Corp (BoFA) will acquire up to 49.9% in Jio Credit Ltd, the wholly-owned lending subsidiary of Jio Financial Services Ltd, for \$1.9 billion, the companies said in a joint statement on Wednesday.

Jio Financial Services is a publicly-listed entity and acts as a holding company, and is the financial services arm of billionaire Mukesh Ambani-backed conglomerate Reliance Industries Ltd. The investment, which values Jio Credit at about \$3.8 billion, will be made through a preferential allotment of equity shares and warrants. The transaction will initially give Bank of America a 26.5% equity interest in Jio Credit, which can rise to 49.9% on exercise of the warrants. The investment, including equity shares and warrants if fully subscribed, would be ₹18,268 crore or \$1.9 billion.

Jio Credit, a non-bank financier regulated by the Reserve Bank of India (RBI), had assets under management (AUM) of ₹30,667 crore, as of 30 June 2026. Its assets under management were at ₹11,665 crore in the year-ago period, showing a massive 163% growth, as per its investor presentation for the June quarter. The lender offers secured credit for individuals as well as enterprises, including retail mortgages and loans against securities (LAS).

"Jio Financial Services is committed to making finance more seamless and simpler for Indians than ever before, leveraging new technology and anchored in the highest standards of governance. Our strategic partnership with Bank of America is a pivotal milestone in this mission," said Mukesh D. Ambani, chairman and managing director of Reliance Industries.

Ambani said that by combining Jio's digital reach with Bank of America's global pedigree, the joint venture will eliminate friction in credit delivery for all Indians.

Following the deal, Jio Credit's board will have equal representation from both partners.



Jio Credit Ltd is a wholly-owned lending subsidiary of Jio Financial Services Ltd.

Its existing management team will continue to oversee strategy and operations, while Jio Credit will remain consolidated as a subsidiary in Jio Financial Services' financial reporting.

This is Jio Financial's third global partnership after the one with BlackRock for mutual funds and with Allianz for insurance.

Financial Services, which has achieved remarkable scale in a short period of time, growing to more than \$3 billion in assets under management in just two years," said Moynihan.

Experts said the deal signifies a milestone for NBFCs with a strong distribution reach and a digital-first engine.

"It is also a very effective channel for the foreign players to get exposure in the retail segment of the Indian market, which the foreign players have themselves avoided through their banking franchise," said Vivek Iyer, partner and national leader financial services - risk advisory at Grant Thornton Bharat. Iyer said

RBI's approval will define the path for foreign players. "Further, we believe that this arrangement will also bring the much-needed global governance practices into an extremely fast paced NBFC lending space, providing greater systemic stability that the RBI intends to achieve in this segment," he added.

DEAL DAY

THE transaction will initially give BoFA a 26.5% stake; can rise to 49.9% on exercise of the warrants

THE company had assets under management (AUM) of ₹30,667 crore as of 30 June 2026

ITS assets under management were at ₹11,665 crore in the year-ago period, a 163% growth

Brian Moynihan, chair and chief executive officer of Bank of America, said India is one of the world's most important growth markets, and that "this investment reflects the bank's confidence in its future, a market we know well and have supported for decades".

"We are excited to become a partner with Jio

Big brands go small as micro-markets offer more bang

FROM PAGE 1

Cross Road on New Kantwadi Road and on 16th Road, betting on neighbourhood footfall rather than a market's pull.

Thakur Village and Borivali West are also emerging as new hubs for restaurant brands, with large, premium gated communities.

Harinder Sahni, chairman and managing director of retail consultancy Wazir Advisors, said consumers are no longer willing to travel an hour or more to shop. It is also because the original appeal of destination retail has now faded. "Convenience is now shaping purchase decisions. E-commerce and quick commerce and local stores are dominating, and so retailers will have to lean on smaller formats," he said.

Luxury retail is watching closely, too. Aditya Birla Fashion and Retail Ltd (ABFRL), which runs Galeries Lafayette in India, is weighing smaller city-format stores closer to affluent pockets instead of bet-



There are only a handful of developers with the scale to build very large shopping centres.

ting everything on large flagships. "You need to move closer to where your customers are," said Sathyajit Radhakrishnan, chief executive, international brands, at ABFRL, pointing to South Mumbai and pockets of Delhi as distinct, self-contained consumption markets in their own right.

Traffic and the clustering of affluent buyers in specific pockets, he said, are what's making micro-markets impossible to ignore.

But the shift isn't purely about consumer preference. It's also a real estate math problem. There are only a handful of developers with the scale to build very large shopping centres, and soaring land and construction costs have made new malls upwards of 500,000 sq ft increasingly hard to pull off, said Anuj Kejriwal, founding partner and chief executive officer (CEO), retail, Europe, the Middle East, and Africa for consultancy Anarock.

He said developers are increasingly favouring open-air, low-rise high streets and neighbourhood strips over capital-heavy malls, and high streets and small-format retail now account for roughly 60% of annual organized retail leasing across top cities.

Micro-markets span the National Capital Region's (NCR's) Golf Course Extension Road and Dwarka Expressway, Bengaluru's ORR-Whitefield-Sarjapur belt, the Mumbai Metropolitan Region's (MMR) Thane and suburbs, and tier-II hubs such as Indore, Jaipur and Lucknow, with food and beverages, quick-service restaurants and direct-to-consumer brands driving demand for 500-10,000 sq ft formats.

Grade A high streets can command ₹200-500 a sq ft a month (800-plus in Khan Market or Linking Road) against ₹200-400-plus in Grade A

malls, but with little to no common area maintenance or revenue share, a structural cost edge over mall leases.

Pushpa Bector, group executive director and business head, DLF Retail, said convenience and experience need to be balanced. Shoppers today want proximity, she said, but they haven't given up on quality or a relevant brand mix, they just want it closer to home.

The developer launched its Midtown Plaza earlier this month in West Delhi's Moti Nagar, built on exactly this bet, bundling shopping, dining, entertainment, wellness and everyday services for a local catchment that isn't inclined to drive to a destination mall for routine visits. The same logic is being applied to its Summit Plazam Gurugram's DLF5.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

Heavy traffic and the clustering of rich buyers in specific pockets are making micro-markets hard to ignore

Yulu raises \$93 mn; GEF leads round

Rwit Ghosh
rwit.ghosh@livemint.com
MUMBAI

Yulu, a mobility-as-a-service startup platform, raised \$87.5 million as part of its Series C round in a mix of equity and debt to expand its electric vehicle operations, the company said. "Over the next two years, we plan to quadruple the number of vehicles on the road from 50,000 to 200,000," company co-founder and chief executive Amit Gupta said in an interview with *Mint*. "A portion of those vehicles will be bought through the equity we've raised, but the rest through debt or leasing."

Of the \$93 million round, \$57.5 million came from global private equity firm GEF Capital Partners, which focuses on backing companies combating climate change and pollution.

A secondary part of \$5.5 million from GEF gave some early institutional investors an exit,



Yulu aims to be profitable before its planned IPO.

Gupta said. Among investors in Yulu's \$2.62 million seed round in 2017 were Firebolt Ventures, 3one4 Capital, Wavemaker Partners, Blume Ventures and Incubate Fund Asia.

The 2017 round saw participation from angel investors, including Freshworks' Girish Mathrubootham, Flipkart's Binny Bansal and InMobi Group's Naveen Tiwari. Debt of \$30 million was also raised from two European lenders.

"The revised timeline is more than an extension. It transforms the economics of our cell business by converting an earlier milestone overhang into a five-year, quarterly PLI opportunity of up to ₹2,400 crore. We hadn't factored any incentives into our business projections after overshooting the original timelines. Ola is now well ahead of the government's revised schedule, and enables us to access the full potential of ₹2,400 crore and receive disbursement as soon as next quarter," said Bhavish Agarwal, chairman and managing director, Ola Electric, according to the company's statement to exchanges.

In an email response, the ministry of heavy industries confirmed Ola's statement.

Since the start of the 2026 financial year, Ola Electric's battery plans have fluctuated due to market conditions. While the company initially planned to build the full 20GWh, it decided to limit it to 6GWh, as that capacity was sufficient to meet demand from its automobile and cell businesses.

manas.pimpalkhare@live-mint.com

For an extended version of this story go to, livemint.com.

Chandra's two tenures at Tata Sons tell two different stories

FROM PAGE 1

merce, with Tata Digital launching its ambitious super-app Tata Neu towards the end of Chandra's first term.

However, a string of challenges hit the group during Chandrasekaran's second term slated to end in February 2027.

TCS reported its first-ever revenue decline since listing in 2004 and was forced to let go of over 12,000 employees over the past year, as artificial intelligence (AI) threatens to upend the information technology (IT) business.

Tata Motors continued its upward journey, successfully splitting its business into specialised passenger and commercial vehicle units.

But its subsidiary Jaguar Land Rover faced multiple

setbacks, including a cyberattack that suspended its production lines, a botched relaunch of the Jaguar brand, and declining sales in key markets.

Tata Steel, too, faced persistent losses in Europe, offsetting the company's performance in India.

These issues were on top of external challenges such as wars, tariffs, and supply chain disruptions, including semiconductor shortages and China's export restrictions on rare-earth magnets.

"Chandra has done well as the chairman, giving balanced performance across the group and its constituencies. This is especially so in the first term," said Kavi Ramachandran, professor of entrepreneurship (practice) at the Indian School of (ISB), Hyderabad.

Group game

The Tata Group delivered a robust performance during Chandrasekaran's first term with underperformance of private businesses catching up in the second.

REPORT CARD OF KEY LISTED TATA GROUP COMPANIES			
	Revenue (in ₹ trillion)	M-cap (in ₹ trillion)	Profit (in ₹ crore)
Tata PV	2.70	1.58	6,340
	3.36	1.09	86,532
TCS	1.18	4.79	26,117
	2.67	8.53	49,210
Tata Steel	1.17	0.47	3,948
	2.32	2.39	10,794
Titan	0.13	0.41	802
	0.88	3.52	5,174
Tata Power	0.28	0.24	745
	0.62	1.21	3,747

Source: Bloomberg, Mint calculations

His second term was, however, mixed with external geopolitical as well as technological challenges, adding to his woes on the business front, he

said. "In short, I would rate him as a very successful leader, who could perhaps have handled some situations better.

Some of the internal management challenges in group companies such as Air India could have been handled better," he said.

The market capitalization of the group's listed companies shows this more clearly.

Between March 2017 and March 2022, the valuation of its listed companies surged three-fold to ₹23.2 trillion, growing at twice the pace of benchmark Sensex.

But in the subsequent four years, it moved barely 4% to ₹24 trillion, far slower than the 23% growth seen by the Sensex over this period.

On the private side of the business, losses mounted, nearly doubling year-on-year (y-o-y) to ₹27,854 crore during the year ended 31 March 2026.

The four new businesses that Tata Sons entered into under Chandrasekaran—Air India, Tata Digital, Tata Electronics, and Agradas—accounted for the lion's share

of the losses as they remained in their growth stage, requiring significant capital investment.

Air India's losses more than doubled to ₹22,238 crore with the carrier having one of its worst-ever years, with a deadly air crash and a surge in fuel costs due to the war in Iran.

Tata Digital was the next big loss accumulator, as neither its super-app nor its e-commerce bets, such as BigBasket and Iimg, saw significant consumer traction.

In fact, the losses at the private businesses were a key hurdle that kept the Tata Sons board from unanimously granting Chandrasekaran a third term in February this year.

Noel Tata, the chair of Tata Trusts, which owns 65.9% of

Tata Sons, had cited the continued losses in the new businesses and the lack of a roadmap for these businesses at the 24 February board meeting.

A key milestone under Chandrasekaran's watch was the group going debt-free: from the ₹20,839 crore in bank borrowings at the end of March 2017, it now has zero borrowings.

The group cut its standalone debt primarily to avoid being listed under a Reserve Bank of India (RBI) guideline, as loans from financial institutions are among the metrics the regulator assessed in the past when classifying upper-layer non-bank lenders such as Tata Sons. For now, Tata Sons' application to surrender its licence as a core investment company remains pending with the Reserve Bank of India.



'Godrej Consumer board was unaware of CEO's exit plans'

Nisaba Godrej for 'more candour and pace' at GCPL, indicates Sitapati quit abruptly

Nehal Chaliawala
nehal.chaliawala@livemint.com
MUMBAI

The board of Godrej Consumer Products Ltd (GCPL) had not discussed a leadership transition when it granted outgoing chief executive (CEO) Sudhir Sitapati a fresh five-year term, chairperson Nisaba Godrej told investors late on Tuesday, hours after the company announced his sudden and immediate exit.

Neither Sitapati nor the company has disclosed the reason for the exit, but comments from both hinted at underlying discord.

Asked to assess Sitapati's five-year tenure, Nisaba Godrej called him one of the smartest people she had worked with, while flagging areas where she thought the company fell short.

"Sometimes we want to say very fancy things on these calls of what we're going to do. But it's basically can we roll up our sleeves and get things done with more candour and pace? And I feel that that layer in GCPL is not as strong as I would like it," she said. "So that's what I'm hoping that Aasif will bring with him while continuing all the good things that were built in the last five years."

Aasif Malbari, GCPL's former global chief financial officer, was appointed managing director and CEO effective 11 August.

In his resignation letter, Sitapati cited his performance, an unusual move for a departing executive. "On a monthly average, from 7 May 2021—the day my appointment was announced—through 9 August, GCPL's total shareholder return has been around 10%, compared with around 8% for the Nifty FMCG index. Today, 97% of analysts rate the stock a buy or hold, among the highest ratings in the sector," he wrote. "I feel that the



Nisaba Godrej was candid in pointing out what she thought were the company's shortcomings during the past five years on Tuesday's investor call.

task I had set for myself here is done and this is the right time to move on." Godrej Consumer Products did not respond to *Mint*'s request for comment. Messages to Sitapati went unanswered. Nisaba Godrej said the transition was

know, a longer period... but it was his request. And since we had a ready successor plan with Aasif within GCPL, we agreed," she said.

Tuesday's comments were no anomaly—public candour has long defined

ating at the 80th or 90th percentile when it comes to the classic playbook: big SKUs (stock-keeping units), general trade distribution and television-led media. But we are probably closer to the 50th percentile when it comes to e-commerce, digital marketing and understanding the disruption AI is going to create," she wrote.

Monish Chatrath, managing partner at consulting firm MGC Global Risk Advisory, said leadership transitions are best viewed through the prism of institutional resilience rather than individual circumstances. "From the outside, one can seldom have visibility into the full constellation of considerations that inform such decisions. It is therefore more useful to focus on the governance architecture within which such transitions are effected," he said.

CEOs at major firms typically plan gradual exits to ensure a smooth transition. Sitapati's abrupt departure rattled investors, sending GCPL shares down 10.55% to ₹10.6 on Wednesday, against a 0.24% decline in the Sensex.

To reassure investors, management said there won't be any sudden changes at the company. The next layer of leadership, which heads country clusters and categories, remains the same, Godrej said. The incoming CEO said that he has already worked with the company's leadership team and is familiar with them. "I think step one would be not to make any large changes overnight," Malbari said on Tuesday's investor call.

Management stopped short of outlining their exact plans for the company going forward, but mentioned that the company will return to having a separate India CEO, a role that Sitapati subsumed when he took over in 2022.

Neethi Lisa Rajan in Mumbai contributed to this story.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

Chinese carmakers' global push aids Indian suppliers

Ayaan Kartik
ayaan.kartik@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

India's largest auto parts maker, Samvardhana Mother International Ltd (SAMIL), sees a fresh growth opportunity in the global expansion of Chinese automakers, as companies such as BYD Co. Ltd, SAIC Motor Corp. Ltd and Chery Automobile Co. Ltd set up manufacturing operations outside China.

Mother's management told *Mint* that while its business in China has largely been with non-Chinese carmakers, it is well positioned to support Chinese companies as they establish factories in Europe, South-East Asia and Latin America.

BYD is setting up a plant in Hungary, with operations expected to begin this year, and started operations at a Brazil plant in 2025. Other Chinese automakers, including Chongqing Changan and Xpeng, are exploring or have begun local assembly in Europe as imports from China face greater regulatory scrutiny.

The trend is also creating indirect opportunities for global supplier units based in India. Tenneco Clean Air India, the local arm of US-based Tenneco, said its European sister firm's growing engagement with Chinese firms could open opportunities for the Indian unit to supply certain parts.

Analysts, however, say the opportunity is likely to be limited to Indian component makers with an established international manufacturing footprint.

Pankaj Mital, whole-time director and president at Mother's, said the company's major business inside China is supporting international non-



BYD is setting up a plant in Hungary, with plans to start operations this year.

REUTERS

Chinese carmakers' operations there. "In China, we have mainly been supporting our international carmakers. Then those companies also started supporting many Chinese carmakers as they have evolved. They also use our products. And they also see us as a potential partner when they come from China into many different parts of the world," Mital said. "If they start manufacturing in other countries, they will also need partners who can make it in that country and support them. So we could be a partner to them also in those countries as they grow," he added.

The opportunity echoes comments by Sonar Comstar managing director and chief executive officer Vivek Vikram Singh to *Mint* in May. "When Chinese OEMs (original equipment manufacturers) set up factories outside is when our opportunity truly arises in the driveline business," Singh said. "We do have a duty disadvantage. Exporting from India to China is not really viable with the current geopolitical and duty environment," he added.

China's scale makes the opportunity significant.

According to Benchmark Mineral Intelligence, China recorded 12.9 million electric vehicle (EV) sales in 2025, up 20% from the previous year. Europe recorded 4.3 million, up 33%, while North America saw 1.8 million, down 4%.

Arvind Chandra, CEO, Tenneco Clean Air India, said the company can gain if Chinese carmakers increase their engagement with sister companies in Europe and other regions where they will expand. "We don't like to compete with our European sister divisions. Just exports-wise, there is enough business to be had, where we can collaborate with each other, we can become a child part supplier, subassembly supplier," he said.

Analysts cautioned that the opportunity will be selective. "As they establish manufacturing outside China, they will progressively need supplier ecosystems closer to their plants. This is driven not only by logistics and cost but increasingly by localization requirements, rules of origin, tariffs and the need to reduce supply-chain concentration," said Harshvardhan Sharma, group head - automotive technology and innovation at Nomura Consulting.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).



ESTER INDUSTRIES LIMITED

CIN: L24111UR1985PLC015063

Regd. Office: Sohan Nagar, P.O. Charubeta Khatima-262308, Distt. Udham Singh Nagar, Uttarakhand
Phone: (05943) 250153-57, Fax: (05943) 250158, Website: [www.esterindustries.com](#), Email: [investor@ester.in](#)

Extract of Consolidated Financial Results for the Quarter ended 30th June 2026

Particulars	Quarter Ended		Year Ended
	30.06.2026	30.06.2025	31.03.2026
Total income	441.96	346.85	1392.72
EBITDA	58.93	28.96	110.56
Profit/(Loss) Before Tax	23.53	(3.81)	(24.28)
Profit/(Loss) After Tax	18.62	(7.16)	(27.47)
Other Comprehensive Income/(Loss)	(0.41)	(0.45)	0.47
Total Comprehensive Income/(Loss)	18.21	(7.61)	(27.00)
Tangible Net Worth	880.22	807.13	782.4

The above is an extract of Unaudited Financial Results and is not a statutory advertisement required under applicable SEBI Regulations. The detailed financial results and investor presentation are available on the websites of the Stock Exchanges, viz. [www.nseindia.com](#) and [www.bseindia.com](#) and on the Company's website, i.e. [www.esterindustries.com](#).

JAIPUR DEVELOPMENT AUTHORITY

Indira Circle, Jawahar Lal Nehru Marg, Jaipur-302004

No. JDA/EE-B-1/2025-26/D-157 Date : 07.08.2026

NOTICE INVITING BID

NIB No.: JDA/EE-B/01/2026-27
(UBN No.: JDA2627WLOB00272)

Online Bids are invited up-to 6:00 PM of 27/08/2026 for "Construction work of Road and Drain near ROB LC-225 and Connecting Areas in Zone-B, JDA, Jaipur". The last date for Applying Bid and making online payment on JDA portal is up-to 6:00 PM of 27/08/2026. The estimated cost of NIB is Rs. 510.88 Lacs. Details may be seen in the Bidding Document at our office or the State Public Procurement Portal website [www.sppp.rajasthan.gov.in](#), [www.eproc.rajasthan.gov.in](#) and [www.jda.rajasthan.gov.in/jda](#)

To participate in the bid, bidder must:-

A. Participate in Tender & Deposit Payment on 'Online Tender Participation' Portal of JDA at [https://jda.rajasthan.gov.in/jda](#) or by Single-Sign-On at [http://service.jaipurjda.org](#).

B. Submit e-Bid on 'e-Procurement Portal' of GOR at [www.eproc.rajasthan.gov.in](#)

Raj Samwadi/C/26/9475 Executive Engineer-B-1

NOTICE INVITING E-TENDER

Gujarat Energy Limited (Erstwhile Gujarat Gas Limited), desires to invite bids against Tender(s) under two bid system through e-tendering portal from eligible and interested parties for the following categories:

Tender ID	Tender Description	Link for accessing the Tender Documents
332898	Hiring of Integrated Drilling Services -IDS for Onshore Blocks in Gujarat - 645	geltender.nprocure.com https://www.gujarat-energy.com/ggi-current-tender/
319131	Supply of Commercial Diaphragm Meters across GEL Locations of Gujarat, Palghar district & Thane Rural, Dadra and Nagar Haveli (DNH), Punjab, Haryana, Madhya Pradesh and Rajasthan.	
332422	Data Gathering and Verification Activities across GEL Operating Areas in Gujarat (Surat & Hazira, Bharuch, Dahej and Narmada GA)	

Any revision, clarifications, corrigenda, addenda, notifications etc. related to this notice will be updated on the above referred websites only. Interested parties should regularly visit websites to keep themselves updated.



State Bank of India
Central Recruitment & Promotion Department
Corporate Centre, Mumbai
Phone: 022-22820427



Recruitment of Specialist Cadre Officers on Contract / Regular Basis

Applications are invited from eligible Indian citizens for the following posts on Contract/Regular basis:

Name of Post	Vacancy	Age (As on 31.07.2026)	
		Min	Max
Deputy Vice President (DVP) – Cyber Innovation & Simulation Lab	1	35	45
Deputy Vice President (DVP) – Citizen Centric Initiatives	1		
Deputy Vice President (DVP) – Cyber Security	2		

Name of Post	Vacancy	Grade	Age (As on 31.07.2026)	
			Min	Max
Deputy Manager- AI- Specialist	25	MMGS-II	25	35
Deputy Manager- Cyber Security Analyst	3			
Deputy Manager- IT Security Expert	2			

Name of Post	Vacancy	Grade	Age (As on 31.07.2026)	
			Min	Max
Manager (Manpower Planning & Recruitment)	1	MMGS-III	28	40
Manager (Learning & Development)	1	MMGS-III	28	40

Name of Post	Vacancy	Grade	Age (As on 31.07.2026)	
			Min	Max
Vice President (Enterprise & Technology Architect)	1	40	48	
Deputy Chief Technology Officer (Enterprise Architecture)	1	42	50	

For eligibility criteria (age, experience, job profile etc.), vacancy details, requisite fees, other details and for online submission of application as well as online payment of application fees log on to Bank's website [https://sbi.bank.in/web/careers/current-openings](#). Refer detailed advertisement to ensure eligibility and other details before applying and remitting fees. For any query, please write to us through link "CONTACT US" → "Post Your Query" which is available on Bank's official website ([https://bank.sbi/web/careers/post-your-query](#))

• DATE FOR FILING ONLINE APPLICATION & PAYMENT OF FEES: FROM 07.08.2026 To 27.08.2026.

Place: Mumbai

General Manager (RP & PM)

UNDERSTAND CULTURE.



EVERY SATURDAY IN HINDUSTAN TIMES



N. Chandrasekaran's successor will have barely six months to rebuild trust between owners and the management.

When silence isn't golden: the rift that led to Chandra's exit

T. Surendar & Satish John
MUMBAI

The most revealing sentence in N. Chandrasekaran's resignation letter wasn't that he had decided to step down as Tata Sons chairman. It was his explanation of why.

After recounting that both the Sir Dorabji Tata Trust and the Sir Ratan Tata Trust had unanimously recommended a five-year extension to his tenure, and that Tata Sons's nomination and remuneration panel had endorsed it, Chandrasekaran wrote that the proposal "was not carried through because one of the Board Members did not support it". Six months had passed since the February board meeting and a decision was not forthcoming—leaving a gap in leadership clarity, which he said was essential for employees, investors, partners, and other stakeholders.

The unnamed board member may never be identified publicly by him.

The fact that the resignation was as much a surprise to Tata insiders as it was to others showed something bigger than a failed reappointment. It showed a communication breakdown between the owners of India's largest business house and its most powerful professional executive.

It is a familiar story in Bombay House. A decade ago, the relationship between Ratan Tata and Cyrus Mistry had sunk to the point where communication had virtually ceased before Mistry's dramatic removal as chairman in 2016. The resulting legal battle consumed years and left lasting scars on the Tata Group.

About two-and-a-half decades earlier, a younger Ratan Tata had to deal with professional satraps in the group such as Russi Mody and Ajit Kerkar while taking the mantle over from JRD Tata.

Today, history appears to echo itself, albeit under very

different circumstances.

For much of Chandrasekaran's tenure there was little organised resistance to his leadership. Personally chosen by Ratan Tata after the Mistry ouster, he inherited extraordinary operational freedom. As Ratan Tata gradually withdrew from day-to-day affairs and later passed away, Chandrasekaran came to dominate the group's strategic direction with few visible checks on his authority. That freedom allowed him to pursue some of the boldest investments in the group's recent history. The balance of power changed when Noel Tata became chairman of Tata Trusts. This fundamentally altered the governance equation.

Tata Trusts, with its controlling 66% stake in Tata Sons, became the effective overseer of Chandrasekaran's investment decisions. As scrutiny over returns from businesses such as Air India and Tata Digital intensified, the differences

His exit followed a six-month deadlock, despite support from Tata Trusts and the nomination committee

widened, with more top names involved.

Whether every reported episode reflected a coordinated power struggle is impossible to establish conclusively. But they suggested an

organisation where communication between ownership and management was broken.

The Tata Group has never found succession easy. When Ratan Tata first searched for his successor, Noel Tata, despite belonging to the Tata family, was not viewed as the natural heir. Cyrus Mistry—part of the Shapoorji Pallonji family, the largest corporate shareholder in Tata Sons—emerged an unexpected choice late in 2012. Chandrasekaran himself was, in many ways, another unconventional selection.

His resignation now leaves Tata Sons with barely six months to identify another leader for an organisation that is considerably more complex than it was in 2017.

For an extended version of the story, go to [livemint.com](#).

N. Chandrasekaran's decision to step down after nine years has exposed a succession-planning gap at Tata Sons

Varun Sood & Satish John
BENGALURU/MUMBAI

Tata Sons chairman N. Chandrasekaran's exit note on Wednesday has put the spotlight on the group's lack of succession planning, an issue that Tata Trusts chairman Noel Tata had highlighted to the Tata Sons board at least twice in past 19 months.

Chandrasekaran, who took over as Tata Sons chairman in February 2017, wrote to the Tata Group holding company's six-member board that he will not offer himself for reappointment when his term ends next February.

Noel Tata, who took over as the chair of the philanthropic entities that control 65.9% of Tata Sons in October 2024 after the demise of his half-brother Ratan Tata, had first enquired about succession planning with Harish Manwani, the chairman of Tata Sons' three-member nomination and remuneration committee (NRC), in January last year.

Manwani "responded positively" to Noel Tata, acknowledging that the committee would look into it, according to two executives privy to the development. In February, Noel Tata again asked the NRC chair whether the group had made any progress on succession planning. There was no clear answer offered by Manwani, according to one executive.

An email sent to Manwani seeking response went unanswered. An email sent to Noel Tata and Tata Trusts also elicited no response. Tata Sons NRC comprises Manwani, Chandrasekaran and Tata Trusts nominee Venu Srinivasan.

As early as July 2025, the two principal entities of Tata Trusts—Sir Ratan Tata Trust and Sir Dorabji Tata Trust—had approved a third term for Chandrasekaran. The trustees even agreed to relax the retirement-age criterion for Chandrasekaran, allowing him to continue as executive chairman



Tata Trusts chairman Noel Tata flagged the need for succession planning but got no clear update on the progress.

beyond his 65th birthday. Chandrasekaran turned 63 in June.

However, Noel Tata's decision to step down from the Tata Group companies board by November, when he turns 70, the mandatory retirement

age for non-executive directors, puts the onus on the six-member board to start the succession planning, said an executive privy to the development.

"The simple point is that the NRC of Tata Sons did not have any succession planning in place," said the first execu-

tion. "This despite a board member repeatedly asking them to have one. That is the question the board of Tata Sons needs to answer."

"There must have been informal discussion and agreement about con-

ness. "It is fair to assume that the NRC had considered Chandra's challenges to be due more to external, uncontrollable factors. The scenario changed only when Noel Tata started signalling the need for a change. In hindsight, one can say that the NRC and board ought to have completed a formal process and avoided precipitation like this, which is bad for everybody."

Chandrasekaran's decision to step down came less than a day after the Godrej Group's flagship company, Godrej Consumer Products Ltd, informed the exchanges on Tuesday of CEO Sudhir Sitapati resigning, even after the board granted Sitapati a second five-year term and shareholders approved the decision on 7 August.

The company appointed its global

chief financial officer Aasif Malbari as the new CEO on the same day. Godrej Consumer chair Nisaba Godrej underlined the importance in an analyst interaction on Tuesday evening.

"So, this reappointment was approved by the GCPL board on 6 May and intimated to the exchanges the same day. The AGM notice went to shareholders on 16 July. At neither point was the change under consideration. Voting had been open since 3 August, and shareholders were casting their votes. The AGM was held on 7 August, and Sudhir resigned on 10th evening as managing director and CEO of GCPL. The board met this afternoon on 11th August and appointed Aasif as MD and CEO with immediate effect. Sudhir wanted this with immediate effect. This was his request. And since we had a ready successor plan in place within GCPL, we agreed," Nisaba Godrej told analysts on Tuesday.

For now, the Tata Group faces four challenges. First, Tata Sons faces a possible market listing, prompted by Reserve Bank of India's regulations, posing an existential dilemma that could fundamentally change how the Tata Group holding firm runs India's largest conglomerate. Secondly, Tata Sons needs to provide an exit for the Shapoorji Pallonji Group, which owns 18.38% of the group company and, over the last year, has twice endorsed the holding company going public.

Ballooning losses in privately held new businesses, including Air India and Tata Digital, are the third challenge. Finally, Noel Tata now has to find a successor to Chandrasekaran.

"There is much relief that the uncertainty has gone," said an observer tracking Bombay House.

He was referring to Chandrasekaran's decision not to seek a renewal, thereby giving the Tata Trusts a free hand to set up a selection committee and look for a successor.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

THE SUCCESSION NOBODY PLANNED

TATA Trusts cleared a third term for Chandrasekaran in July 2025 and agreed to relax age criterion

NOEL Tata's planned board exit will put the onus on Tata Sons board to find Chandra's successor

CHANDRA'S exit gives Tata Trusts a free hand to form a selection committee and find a successor

TATA Sons faces a possible listing, exit of SP Group and losses at Air India and Tata Digital

Chandra to exit Tata Sons as efforts to resolve rift falter

FROM PAGE 1

ors Harish Manwani and Anita Marangoly George.

The February episode was a rare challenge to Chandrasekaran, who had previously enjoyed the confidence of the Tata Sons board. It also exposed growing differences between the Tata Sons board and Tata Trusts, the latter owning 65.9% of the former.

The two sides continued discussions. Over the past six months, Chandrasekaran and Noel Tata held at least two closed-door meetings to discuss the group's roadmap, one executive said.

In the last week of June, senior executives from Air India, Tata Electronics and Tata Digital also made presentations to

Noel Tata, Chandrasekaran and the Tata Sons board, the executive said, adding these did not resolve Noel Tata's concerns.

Tata's concerns span some of the Group's biggest bets under Chandrasekaran—from the turnaround of Air India and the creation of an e-commerce platform through Tata Digital to battery manufacturing through Agratas, iPhone assembly for Apple, and semiconductor manufacturing through Tata Electronics. The four businesses reported a combined loss of ₹29,924 crore in FY26, according to Tata Sons' annual report.

On Wednesday evening, Chandrasekaran called about two dozen senior Tata Group executives to Starbucks on the ground floor of Bombay House,



Chandrasekaran's decision now leaves Tata Trusts facing the immediate challenge of finding his successor.

the corporate headquarters of Tata Sons, according to people aware of the development. In a 20-minute pep talk, he sought to assuage concerns among

employees, telling them that Tata was a revered name with a strong talent pool. He signed off by telling them not to take the interaction as his farewell

speech, as he would remain with the Tata Group until February.

Under Tata Sons' Articles of Association, the chairman will be appointed by a five-member selection committee.

Three members are jointly nominated by the Sir Dorabji Tata Trust (SDTT) and Sir Ratan Tata Trust (SRTT), one by the Tata Sons board, and one independent member is selected by Tata Sons. The chairman of the selection committee is chosen by SDTT and SRTT from among their three nominees.

SDTT and SRTT own 27.98% and 23.56%, respectively, of Tata Sons. Other Tata trusts own 14.4%, giving the philanthropic entities a combined 65.9% stake. The remaining stakes are owned by the Shapoorji Pallonji Group (18.38%), nine Tata Group companies (12.86%) and seven individuals (2.87%). The selection process, however, could be complicated by a separate dispute, after the Maharashtra charity commissioner prohibited SRTT from taking decisions or holding board meetings.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

Chandrasekaran said his decision was linked to his reappointment not receiving unanimous support

Group's market cap tripled under Chandra

Niti Kiran & Mayur Bhalerao
MUMBAI

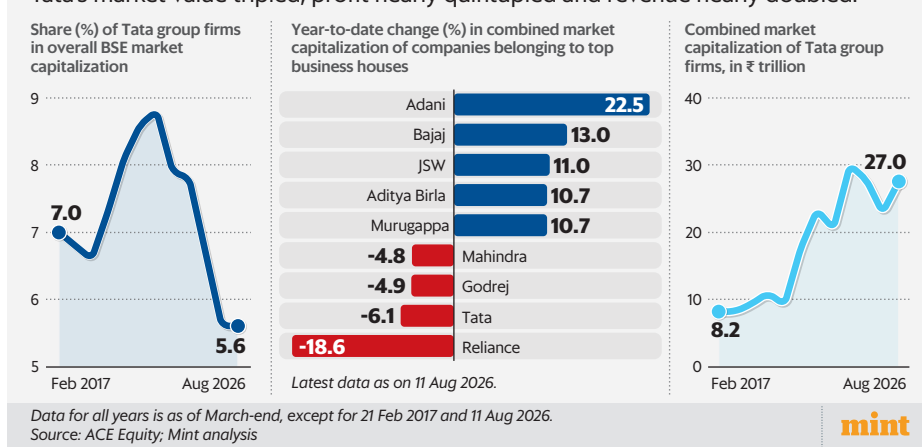
As India's largest conglomerate prepares for a leadership transition, the numbers behind N. Chandrasekaran's nine years at the helm of the Tata Group tell a story of significant value creation. The group's combined market capitalization has more than tripled since he took charge in 2017, while net profit has risen nearly five-fold and revenue almost doubled. Chandrasekaran on Wednesday announced his resignation seven months before his second term ends in February.

"Chandrasekaran's record must be assessed in terms of both absolute and relative wealth creation. On an absolute basis, the performance has been impressive: the group's net profit has increased nearly five-fold, from about ₹35,000 crore to ₹1.7 trillion, while revenue has almost doubled and its combined market capitalization has risen about 3.3 times," said Anand K. Rath, co-founder of MIRA Money.

"The Tata Group should not

Chandra's scorecard

Tata's market value tripled, profit nearly quintupled and revenue nearly doubled.



be viewed as a single stock, given its portfolio of more than 100 companies. Several listed businesses, including Trent, Titan, Tata Motors, Indian Hotels and Tata Consumer Products, have delivered multi-bagger returns," he added.

He built his reputation over a three-decade career at the group's crown jewel, as he served as the chief executive of Tata Consultancy Services (TCS) before he was Tata Sons

chairman. TCS now makes for about 32% of group valuation, down from 67% five years ago.

The group has relatively underperformed, largely as TCS has been a drag in recent years. Moreover, only a few Tata firms were listed during this period, while India's overall market cap surged through numerous listings, he said.

Amid market volatility, the group's market cap is down about 6% on year. Other top

conglomerates show a mixed trend: Adani firms surged 22%, while Reliance fell 19%.

The decline in Tata's market value seems to reflect its exposure to underperforming sectors more than governance issues, said Harshal Dasani, business head at INVasset PMS. "A smooth handover at the AGM could quickly narrow this discount, while a prolonged vacuum may widen it," [niti.k@livemint.com](#)

Harsh Kumar & Dharendra Kumar
NEW DELHI

The Centre is unlikely to intervene in the leadership turmoil at Tata Sons following the resignation of its chairman, viewing the matter as an internal issue of the conglomerate that should be resolved within the group, according to two government officials.

The government's position is that it would consider stepping in only if the Tata Group or relevant stakeholders formally seek its involvement. As a matter of policy, the government generally refrains from intervening in the internal governance of private companies, the first of the two officials cited earlier said, both speaking on condition of anonymity.

According to the second official, the government currently sees no grounds to get involved in the Tata Group's internal leadership issue, as it is a matter for the group's shareholders and management to resolve.



The government would consider stepping in only if the Tata Group or relevant stakeholders formally seek its involvement.

Queries emailed to the spokespersons of the Prime Minister's Office, the ministries of finance and corporate affairs, Securities and Exchange Board of India and the Tata Group were not immediately answered.

The uncertainty was triggered on Wednesday after N. Chandrasekaran said he would not seek reappointment when his term ends in February.

In a statement, he said that the Sir Dorabji Tata Trust and

Sir Ratan Tata Trust had unanimously recommended a third five-year extension of his tenure. The proposal was also recommended by the Tata Sons' Nomination and Remuneration Committee and the board.

However, when the proposal was considered at a board meeting on 24 February 2026, one board member withheld support. In the absence of unanimous support, Chandrasekaran said he chose to defer the decision.

Tata Sons is a highly

respected and important company, and its management has a significant bearing on the broader Indian economy, said Dinesh Kumar Mittal, former secretary at the ministry of corporate affairs.

"Beyond that, there is also a global dimension to this development. International investors will be looking at the stability and continuity of large Indian companies. If Mr. Chandrasekaran, who has done a wonderful job, were to step down, it would be imperative for Tata Sons to announce a successor who is equally capable, if not better. That would be important not only for ensuring stability and confidence in the market, but also for maintaining India's reputation and credibility globally," added Mittal.

The Centre has intervened in corporate affairs in the past when public interest or serious governance and financial concerns were involved, but does not ordinarily intervene in routine corporate disputes, the second official said.

[harsh.kumar@live-mint.com](#)



NEWS NUMBERS

175,000

THE NUMBER of visas revoked by the US state department under President Donald Trump due to criminal activity, visa violations and national security concerns.

13.4 mn

COLOMBIA'S COFFEE output in 2025 in 60kg bags, as the country's exports face a pause following a devastating earthquake that blocked key supply routes.

\$15.3 mn

THE AMOUNT the US subsidiary of Glenmark Pharmaceuticals agreed to pay Humana Inc. to settle generic drug price-fixing and antitrust litigation allegations.

₹25.8 tn

THE WEALTH of Mukesh Ambani's family, as it remained India's richest business family on the 2026 Barclays Hurun list despite an 8.5% decline in fortune.

225

THE TOTAL footprint of ride-hailing major Uber as it enters 100 new cities across the country with its bike and taxi services.

HOWINDIALIVES.COM

Apollo Hospitals net profit up 34%

Apollo Hospitals Enterprise Ltd beat street estimates for the June quarter as high speciality volumes continued to boost growth, and the hospital chain continued its capacity expansion. Apollo posted its results for first quarter of fiscal year 2027 (QIFY27) on Wednesday evening, with revenue growing 21% to ₹7,043 crore and net profit growing 34% to ₹581 crore. Its earnings before interest, taxes, depreciation, and amortization (Ebitda) grew 28% year-on-year to ₹1,092 crore with margin expanding to 15.5%. The company's revenue grew 22% y-o-y to ₹3,567 crore as compared to ₹2,935 crore in QIFY26. Revenue was driven by a robust increase in volume in Congo T specialities, which include cardiology, oncology, neurology, gastroenterology, orthopaedics, and transplants, as well as high-complexity clinical work, the company said in a release.

JESSICA JANI



The bank has also seen lower delinquency in the portfolio underwritten through its BRE.

MINT

SBI uses AI to underwrite loans

State Bank of India (SBI) used artificial intelligence (AI) and digital data to underwrite nearly ₹1 trillion of loans of up to ₹5 crore each to medium, small and micro enterprises (MSMEs) in fiscal year 2026 (FY26), reducing the workload of relationship managers.

The bank has also seen lower delinquency in the portfolio underwritten through its business rule engine (BRE), managing director Rama Mohan Rao Amara said. The scale of AI-assisted underwriting marks a shift in how the country's largest lender is processing smaller business loans, with technology taking on much of the information-gathering and preliminary analysis that relationship managers previously handled. SBI's control risk unit regularly samples cheques processed by AI to identify errors and determine whether the models need further training.

SHUBHANA SHAIKH

Grasim swings to first-quarter profit

Grasim Industries swung to a standalone profit in the first quarter on Wednesday, helped by strong earnings in its fibre business, which supplies materials used in textiles and clothing, and narrower losses in its newer ventures. The Aditya Birla Group flagship's standalone net profit came in at ₹63.22 crore (\$6.63 million) for the quarter ended 30 June, compared with a net loss of ₹118 crore a year earlier. Grasim's fibre business reported a 12% year-on-year rise in revenue. Analysts had expected a sharp improvement in Grasim's quarterly earnings, as higher prices boosted profitability at its fibre business while losses narrowed at its paints and business-to-business e-commerce ventures. Brokerage ICICI Securities had forecast Grasim's standalone operating profit would roughly double from a year earlier, while Antique Stock Broking expected a 77% rise.

REUTERS

Central Bank raises \$250 mn via FCNR

State-owned lender Central Bank of India has mobilised \$250 million under the FCNR-B window introduced by the Reserve Bank of India (RBI), a senior bank official said on Wednesday.

Central Bank of India has surpassed the \$100 million target set for July, garnering \$250 million.

"We have surpassed the July target set internally, and mobilised \$250 million under FCNR - B," Kalyan Kumar, managing director and chief executive officer of Central Bank of India, said on the sidelines of the annual FIBAC event here.

He said that the Central Bank of India has raised funds through its GIFT City branch and has set a target of \$400 million by September end, the closure date fixed by RBI for the special swap window. During the post-June quarter earnings conference, Kumar had said that the Bank expects to accumulate a total of \$400 million.

PTI

'Iran plans to join Brics development bank soon'

Iran will soon join the New Development Bank, the development lender established by the Brics group of nations, central bank governor Abdolnaser Hemmati said in a state media report published on Wednesday ahead of a BRICS finance meeting in India. Iran remains under sweeping US and international sanctions, and it has yet to reach a peace deal to end the current conflict with the US and Israel, giving Tehran added incentive to seek alternative financial channels outside the dollar system.

Iran joined Brics in 2024 as the group expanded, in a move aimed at deepening economic ties among emerging economies, and it has since made clear its desire to become a member and shareholder of the NDB.

REUTERS

IEA sees larger oil supply deficit despite hit to demand

Oil markets face a shortfall of 1.8 million barrels a day due to maritime disruptions

Bloomberg
feedback@livemint.com

Global oil inventories will tumble this quarter at more than twice the rate previously estimated as the Iran war flares again, even as the hit to demand from high prices deepens, the International Energy Agency (IEA) said.

Oil markets face a shortfall of 1.8 million barrels a day as "renewed hostilities and maritime disruptions" undermine a production recovery, the IEA said in its monthly report. For 2026 as a whole, the deficit will likely be the widest in five years.

Stockpiles are tightening again even as elevated fuel prices prompt the agency to deepen estimates for this year's decline in global oil demand by almost 50% to 1.6 million barrels a day. That's the biggest slump in annual average terms since the 2020 covid pandemic.

While a brief ceasefire between the US and Iran in mid-June revived oil exports from the Persian Gulf, shipping and regional energy infrastructure are once again under fire. That's pushing up the cost of fuels such as gasoline and diesel—the workhorse of the global economy—and squeezing consumers.

Still, the output declines are far smaller than some of the worst-case scenarios painted early in the war, having been tempered by an array of workarounds. Those include alterna-



REUTERS

tive pipelines used by Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates and a network of shuttle tankers plying the Strait of Hormuz. US energy secretary Chris Wright said Tuesday that 9 million barrels a day has escaped in the past week, almost half prewar volumes.

The world's depleted inventories ought to be replenished next year after oil markets tip back into oversupply, according to the Paris-based IEA. Members of the organization such

as the US, Japan and Germany will need to refill emergency oil reserves after announcing a record release of stocks in March, the agency said.

"Although the market is projected to return to surplus towards the end of this year, risks remain substantial and the urgency of reopening the Strait has increased, as previously available inventory buffers are rapidly depleting," the agency said.

Mobile tariffs set to rise as Airtel scraps entry-level plan

FROM PAGE 1

er-data plans. The hike also aligns with Airtel's ongoing push to restructure tariffs to sustain average revenue per user (Arpu) and boost its return on capital employed (RoCE). In its FY26 annual report, the company highlighted lingering challenges in monetizing its 5G network.

"Airtel's withdrawal of the ₹299 and ₹319 plans is its first significant move in the current cycle to raise prepaid Arpu. It is not a conventional tariff hike because the ₹349 plan offers more data, but it forces users into a higher minimum spend," said independent telecom analyst Parag Kar. "Removing the ₹319 monthly plan is particularly saying that users who want the same 1.5 GB per day must now pay ₹349 for only 28 days."

"This seems a well-thought-out strategy from Airtel. Given the increase in data usage, they would have seen this as an opportunity to upgrade the subscriber base and grow revenue," said Faisal Kawoosa, chief analyst at technology consultancy firm Techcar.

Kawoosa said investors will see this as a positive move. He also said rivals may follow suit by withdrawing their own lower-priced plans to drive Arpu higher. If they don't, Airtel risks losing price-sensitive subscri-

Rising bills

Tariff hikes are used to improve Arpu

Arpu comparison		
	Jun 2025	Jun 2026
Airtel	250	264
Reliance Jio	208.8	215.6
Vodafone Idea	165	177

Tariff tussle

- When lowest tariff plans are removed, subscribers move up the price charts
- BofA Securities in July had estimated the "next headline tariff hike to be around Mar/Apr-27"
- The last headline tariff hike was announced in June 2024
- In August 2025, telcos tweaked their base price plans to push subscribers to recharge at higher value.

Arpu or average revenue per user is a key industry metric and indicates how much telco earns per customer.

Source: Company filings, Mint research, BofA report

mint

PRATEEK KUMAR/MINT

ers to Vodafone Idea or Jio.

In a like-to-like comparison, Jio currently has an entry-level plan of Rs 299, in which it offers 1.5 GB data per day for 28 days. Vodafone Idea has an entry-level plan of Rs 299, in which it offers 1 GB per day for 28 days, per their websites.

Queries emailed to Bharti Airtel, Reliance Jio and Vodafone Idea were unanswered at the time of publishing.

This isn't the first time in recent months that an operator has phased out a budget pack. Last August, Reliance Jio removed its entry-level ₹249 plan (1GB daily data) from online platforms, a move that

was then matched by Bharti Airtel and Vodafone Idea.

In July 2024, telecom operators implemented their first major tariff hikes in over two years, led by Reliance Jio's 12% to 25% price increase across plans. Over the past year, however, operators have taken opposing views on further price increases. While Airtel and Vodafone Idea pushed for another round of hikes, Jio ruled out immediate headline price increases, expressing confidence that rising 5G adoption would organically drive its Arpu growth.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

PSU NBFCs go slow on offshore borrowing as cost edge shrinks

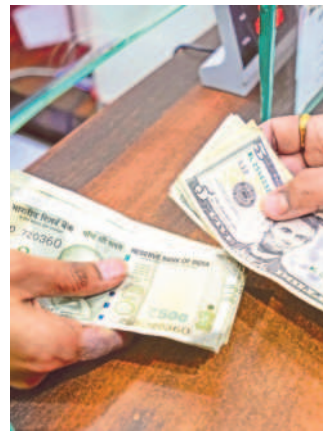
FROM PAGE 1

was not much Indian paper, they used to trade at around 100 bps over US yields. Now, the spreads have gone up, and they are anywhere between 110 and 130 bps," a senior merchant banker said.

On 5 June, announcing its monetary policy review, RBI announced it will provide a concessional forex swap facility for external commercial borrowings (ECBs) raised by PSUs and banks until 31 December 2026, for a maximum of five-year tenure. Under the scheme, RBI will effectively bear a fixed swap cost of 1.5% per annum for hedging the dollar exposure, allowing borrowers to access overseas funds at significantly lower overall costs.

The cost calculation showed the narrowing gap. For a three-year US dollar bond, a treasury yield of around 4.27%, combined with a spread of about 110 bps, takes the base borrowing cost to roughly 5.37% on a semi-annual basis. The RBI's 1.5% hedging facility then adds to the effective cost, while another roughly 30 bps may be required for coupon hedging, according to market estimates.

That takes the overall cost of dollar borrowing to around 7.20% compared with domestic bond yields of around 7.28-7.30% for the PSU issuers. The difference is a mere 8-10 basis points, significantly reducing the incentive to borrow abroad. Coupon hedging



RBI's concessional forex swap facility is till 31 December 2026.

PTI

refers to hedging the periodic interest payments on a foreign-currency borrowing. The RBI facility does not cover this component, which can add roughly another 30 bps to the cost.

Currently, dollar-rupee forward rates are hovering a tad over 3% annually.

An email sent to public sector non-banks Rural Electrification Corp (REC), Power Finance Corp (PFC) and Housing Urban Development Corp Ltd (Hudco) did not elicit any response until press time.

"From a rate perspective, the difference is narrowing and that is one thing to worry about," said the senior banker cited above.

On 7 August, frequent AAA rated issuers such as REC raised ₹3,000 crore through domestic bonds maturing in three years at 7.28%

and ₹3,346 crore via 15-year paper at 7.49%. Last month, Small Industries Development Bank of India (SIDBI) raised ₹8,000 crore via November 2029 bond at 7.29%, merchant bankers said.

"The RBI window has created an alternative funding channel, but it has not made overseas funding an automatic winner. Elevated US yields have narrowed the pricing advantage of ECBs over domestic funding, while PSU domestic bond borrowings themselves have weakened amid elevated and volatile bond yields," Venkatakrishnan Srinivasan, founder of Rockford Fincap, said.

Since the US-Iran war broke out on 28 February, yield on the 10-year benchmark US treasury yield has gone up by 65 bps to 4.68%, while that of the corresponding domestic government bond yield is up only 10 bps to 6.78% as of 11 August, Bloomberg data showed.

The overseas market has also become crowded, as banks have been raising US dollars to fund the FCNR deposits that has created a supply overhang in the dollar market for PSUs.

According to data released by RBI on 1 August, banks raised around \$36.73 billion through the FCNR route until 31 July and the market expects the mobilization to reach around \$90 billion by September end, when the special FCNR deposit window closes.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

SACU group to launch trade talks

India and the South Africa-led SACU (South African Customs Union) group on Wednesday signed a roadmap for launching negotiations for a preferential trade agreement in goods to boost economic ties.

The terms of reference, a roadmap which sets out broad parameters for trade talks, were signed here by chief negotiators of the two regions in the presence of commerce and industry minister Piyush Goyal.

The five members of SACU are Botswana, Eswatini (formerly Swaziland), Lesotho, Namibia and South Africa. ToRs are essentially the negotiating mandate, or roadmap, that sets out what the countries will negotiate and the broad parameters within which negotiations will take place. Both sides are looking to conclude the negotiations within one year. Under such pacts, two trading partners provide duty concessions to each other on a number of goods to boost two-way commerce.

PTI



Net profit for the April to June period was T\$59.97 billion.

ISTOCKPHOTO

Foxconn Q2 profit rises on AI demand

Taiwan's Foxconn, the world's largest contract electronics maker, reported on

Wednesday a 35% rise in second-quarter profit, beating analyst forecasts, on continued strong demand for artificial intelligence (AI), which it predicted would drive growth this year. Net profit for the April to June period for Nvidia's biggest server maker and Apple's top iPhone assembler was T\$59.97 billion (\$1.86 billion), versus an LSEG consensus estimate of T\$58.8 billion and compared with T\$44.4 billion a year earlier. In an earnings release, it stuck to its previous forecast of "strong" growth for revenue this year and said it also saw strong AI demand driving growth throughout the year. The company does not give numeric forecasts. The company said its cloud and networking products segment, which includes AI servers, accounted for 51% of second-quarter revenue, exceeding 50% for the first time, while its smart consumer electronics products segment, which includes iPhones, accounted for 29%. "AI-related business performance will continue to grow in the third quarter," the company said.

REUTERS



Freelancing for freedom? Build a financial safety net

Multiple income streams offer a buffer against payment delays, lost clients and AI-led change

Ann Jacob
ann.jacob@livemint.com
MUMBAI

Many people who endure strenuous commutes and the grind of the 9-to-5 routine look at freelancing with dreamy eyes. For many freelancers and gig workers, escaping monthly paychecks has worked out to be a trail of freedom—whether leading global teams from home in New Delhi, crafting content from Guwahati or taking art therapy sessions in Kochi.

Independent work holds an undeniable allure. Yet, this liberating lifestyle calls for greater financial care given the lack of a traditional safety net. Income can arrive irregularly, clients can disappear and artificial intelligence (AI) threatens to take away work.

Freelancers need to diversify their offerings, build multiple income streams and manage money mindfully.

Freedom and risks

Many move to gig work seeking flexibility. For New Delhi-based 44-year-old Garima Om, who has worked independently for over a decade, the transition came after hitting a financial wall in corporate life. “Freelancing became more appealing after I hit the upper earning ceiling in my 9-5 job,” Om said.

Her work has evolved from resume writing and children’s theatre workshops to working as an interlocutor, creating handmade home décor and leading global job-readiness projects. “Freelancing offered greater independence, flexibility and the freedom to explore different skills while creating additional earning opportunities.”

For Padma Choudhury, 34, a content writer and social media strategist from Guwahati who quit her corporate writing job in 2021, the appeal was personal alignment. “As a freelancer, you have an option to renegotiate your fees, redefine the scope or walk away if it is no longer working for you,” she said.

Corporate shifts are also driving gig work. Ramani Dathi, chief financial officer at TeamLease Services Ltd, said demand for gig workers has surged, partly because of tech disruption and evolving workforce needs. “Especially over the last two years, or ever since AI has taken over, companies are needing fewer people. In many cases, they may not need someone to work for a whole month or year. Full-time jobs are also not that many now, so many don’t even have a choice and start with freelancing or fractional roles,” Dathi said.

But freelancing also brings financial and operational risks that the salaried may not face. “No fixed schedule means clients can often become demanding irrespective of weekends, off-working hours, or festivals,” Om said, citing the lack of job security and perks.

“You have to raise invoices, follow up and manage different payment cycles,” Choudhury said. “Some clients pay immediately, while others can take even 90 days. There are also costs people may not be aware of, like software and subscriptions. Depending on the kind of work you do, you may need premium tools, publications and more. Together, these can add up.”

Choudhury also highlighted the social aspect of office life, noting that freelancers can miss lunches, chats with colleagues and team outings. Freelancing can get quite lonely, espe-

Diversifying not just investments but income

Freelancing and working gigs offer freedom but also require financial discipline. Independent workers must master income stacking, budgeting and risk management.



GARIMA OM (44)
New Delhi,
Independent project lead, Interlocutor

“Keeping expenses modest has been the biggest advantage. Setting prices was challenging initially because there are no benchmarks for comparison.”



PADMAJA CHOUDHURY (34)
Guwahati,
Content writer and social media strategist

“I realized that a monthly SIP structure was not working, so instead of stopping completely, I divided the investment and started investing weekly.”



MEGHNA GIRISH (31)
Kochi,
Art therapist, PhD

“I built multiple streams of income. If for a week I don’t have any talks or workshops, I have orders to sell my art. It balances the whole balance sheet.”



JADYN FERNANDES (22)
Mumbai,
Photographer, videographer and musician

“It’s very important to have a second, third, or even fourth source of income because one is not enough to be honest in this day and age.”



Advantages of freelancing

- ▶ No cap on earning potential, as one can negotiate fees as per demand
- ▶ Control over work hours, location, client selection, and bandwidth
- ▶ Freedom to explore multiple creative passions and monetize skills
- ▶ Flexibility to plan work commitments around personal priorities

Hidden costs and risks

- ▶ No paid time off, corporate perks, or fixed working hours
- ▶ Rapid AI advancements threaten single-skill demand
- ▶ Premium software tools, upgrades, and subscriptions can pile up

Income stacking model

- ▶ Diversify specialized skills into multiple services or offerings
- ▶ Offer sessions, workshops, sales, classes to maintain cash flow
- ▶ Substitute multiple low-paying gigs with quality clients to avoid burnout

Cash flow, budgeting and pricing

- ▶ If SIPs trigger anxiety, split investments into smaller installments
- ▶ Keep at least 6 months of expenses in flexi-deposits or arbitrage funds.
- ▶ Keep emergency funds strictly separated from equity growth assets

mint

GOPAKUMAR WARRIER/MINT

cially when working alone.

Income diversification

As market demand fluctuates, freelancers need to build financial resilience by stacking revenue streams across complementary areas.

In Kochi, 31-year-old Meghna Girish, an art therapist with a PhD who has worked independently for seven years, built multiple income streams around her field. “I do different formats, I sell my art, I do classes, I take sessions online and I do workshops to raise awareness. If for a week I don’t have any commitments in terms of talks or workshops, I have orders to sell my art. It balances the whole balance sheet.”

She said that she needs to reinvest in her business via upgrades and gadgets to offer multiple services.

In Mumbai, 22-year-old Jady Fernandes runs photography and videography brand *The Framed Fusion* while also performing as the singer and guitarist for his band, *Organized Chaos*.

“I have two income streams which were both hobbies that I’ve turned into something I can make money from,” Fernandes said. “It’s very important to

have a second, third or even (a) fourth source of income.”

Cash flow and budgeting

Managing money when income arrives in uneven bursts requires caution and discipline.

For Choudhury, erratic payments initially created financial anxiety, causing her to hoard cash despite having a three-year emergency buffer. “I eventually realized that a monthly SIP structure was not working psychologically for me because payments from clients came in at different times,” Choudhury said.

“Instead of stopping my SIPs, I divided the investment into four instalments and started investing weekly. It worked much better because the amount going out at one time felt smaller and matched my cash flow,” she added.

For Om, a moderate lifestyle is the ultimate cushion. “Keeping expenses modest has been the biggest advantage,” Om said. “Since there is no dependence on frequent shopping, partying or expensive outings, fluctuations in income are much easier to manage.”

Her business overheads, including

laptops, internet, software and occasional co-working spaces, remain minimal compared with her earnings. Pricing services correctly and setting professional boundaries are key hurdles. “Setting prices was challenging initially because there are no benchmarks or reference points,” Om struggled with acquaintances seeking free services and favours, which taught her the importance of setting boundaries and learning to say no.

Fernandes said he experienced burnout by undercharging and taking on too many low-paying gigs. “For three years, I chose quantity over quality,” he said. Now I’d rather take up one client who pays me for quality.”

Suresh Sadagopan, founder of Ladder7 Financial Advisors calls to keep over six months of total living expenses, including EMIs in flexi-deposits, liquid or arbitrage funds. Along with keeping money allocated for short-term goals separate from equity assets.



Scan the QR code to read an extended version of this story.

Starting a family-funded NGO? Choose the right legal structure

Shaishavi Kadakia &
Sachi Shah

I have inherited a substantial sum from my grandfather, who supported education causes and urged me in his will to set up an NGO in his name. I want to manage the funds and ensure they are used properly. How can I do this legally?

—Name withheld on request



nise six others willing to participate and aligned with your objectives.

Once you choose the structure, its constitutional documents should be carefully drafted to reflect your grandfather’s philanthropic vision and your other objectives. After the entity is formed and registered with the relevant authority, where required, it may apply for registration under the Income-tax Act, 2025, to claim tax exemption on its income.

If you are not an Indian citizen, the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Act, 2010, will apply to your donations to the entity, even if you are an Overseas Citizenship of India (OCI) cardholder.

Finally, setting up and running an NGO is a significant ongoing commitment. Ensure you have the time, infrastructure and professional support required before proceeding.

Kadakia is a partner, and Shah, a senior associate, at Cyril Amarchand Mangaldas.

Do you have a personal finance query? Send in your queries at mintmoney@livemint.com and get them answered by industry experts.

ASK MINT ESTATE PLAN

To establish a charitable entity—an NGO or foundation—in your grandfather’s name, you must choose the appropriate legal structure: a public charitable trust, a Section 8 Company under the Companies Act, 2013, or a charitable society, depending on factors such as the degree of control, confidentiality, liability, number of members and the state. A public charitable trust is managed by trustees for charitable purposes set out in a trust deed. You can serve as a trustee, though having at least one more is advisable. Maharashtra, Gujarat and Rajasthan regulate trusts through a Charity Commissioner; elsewhere, in the absence of such legislation, public trusts are governed by general principles of trust law.

A Section 8 company is licensed by the Registrar of Companies to undertake charitable activities. Its income must be used solely for its stated objects, and profits cannot be distributed as dividends. You can be a member and director, but need one other member and director.

A society can be formed for any literary, scientific or charitable purpose and must be registered with the local Registrar of Societies. Like public trusts, compliance requirements differ across states. Since a society requires at least seven members, it may not suit your purpose unless you can orga-

Compare NRE FD rates

Non-resident Indians (NRIs) can open NRE fixed deposits with different Indian banks. The benefit of an NRE deposit is that it can be opened simply by making inward remittance to India in any freely convertible currency. Another benefit is that the interest earned on NRE deposits are tax-free and the deposit is fully repatriable, allowing NRIs to transfer funds back to their country of residence without restrictions. NRE FDs can be opened and managed online too with Indian banks. NRIs can also obtain loan against NRE FDs which can be used for a variety of purposes. These loans can be granted to the NRI in India or outside India (by overseas branch of Indian banks) or even to third parties.



NRE Term Deposits Interest Rates (%) upto ₹1 crore				
	1 to < 2 years	2 to < 3 years	3 to < 5 years	5 years and above
DCB Bank	6.90-7.10	6.90-7.50	7.00-7.10	7.00-7.50
Jammu & Kashmir Bank	6.55-6.60	6.75-7.05	6.80	6.85
YES Bank	6.65-7.25	6.90-7.00	7.00	6.75
RBL Bank	7.00-7.20	7.20	7.00-7.20	6.70
Tamilnad Mercantile Bank	6.60-7.25	7.00	6.70	6.70
IndusInd Bank	6.75-6.90	7.00	6.65-7.00	6.50-6.65
Dhanlaxmi Bank	6.25-7.10	6.25-6.50	6.50-7.25	6.50-6.60
Axis Bank	6.25-6.50	6.50	6.50	6.50
ICICI Bank	6.25-6.30	6.30-6.45	6.45-6.50	6.50
Federal Bank	6.25-6.60	6.40	6.40-6.70	6.40
City Union Bank	6.50-7.25	6.50	6.50-6.55	6.25-6.55
Karur Vysya Bank	6.55-6.20	6.55	6.55	6.25-6.55
Kotak Mahindra Bank	6.35-6.55	6.80	6.40	6.25
Canara Bank	6.25-6.60	6.25	6.25	6.25
HDFC Bank	6.25-6.45	6.45	6.40-6.50	6.15-6.40

Data taken from respective bank’s website as on 11 August 2026; Only main entity of the merged banks are taken. Banks which merged with its main entity are removed from the table; The list of 15 banks is based on highest fixed deposit rates available for 5 years and above.

GOPAKUMAR WARRIER/MINT

Source: BankBazaar

YOUR CHILD MAY REWRITE THEIR FUTURE. CAN YOUR INVESTMENTS KEEP UP?



POWER
POINT

RAVI KUMAR T.V.

Respond to this column at
feedback@livemint.com

Your child will study mechanical engineering and then start a yoga studio. Get ready for life’s surprises with SIPs.

I smiled—not just because it was a clever advertisement, but because it made me pause. As a parent, it struck a chord. My 22-year-old daughter recently graduated in Industrial Design, and watching her discover her interests and forge her own path has been rewarding. My 14-year-old son, meanwhile, eats, sleeps and breathes football. Ask him what he wants to do, and the answer comes instantly. But will that still be his dream ten years from now? I don’t know. And that’s perfectly okay.

The advertisement stayed with me long after I boarded the flight. Not because it was about SIPs, but because it touched on something bigger. As parents, we spend years planning our children’s future—schools, colleges, careers and opportunities. We want to give them every advantage. Yet one thing life has taught me is that children are wonderfully unpredictable.

Perhaps our role isn’t to predict who they will become, but to

ensure money never limits who they can become. If their future is increasingly difficult to predict, shouldn’t our investment strategies evolve, too?

A changing future

Twenty years ago, few parents imagined careers such as AI specialist, UX designer, sustainability consultant, content creator or drone pilot. Today, they are real professions. Twenty years from now, many jobs our children pursue may not even exist. Technology will change, industries will evolve, and new professions will emerge as others disappear. That makes parenting both exciting and humbling. We can teach values, nurture curiosity and build resilience, but we cannot predict the world our children will enter. That’s why true wealth planning matters more than ever.

Planning for surprises

Every parent asks familiar questions: Which school is best? Which college should they attend? Which career offer stability? All are important. But ask parents whose children are in their 20s or 30s, and you’ll hear a common theme: few follow the script. Some change careers, study abroad or start businesses. Others discover passions, choose purpose over pay or redefine success. That’s not uncertainty to fear. That’s life unfolding as it should.

This is where parents ask the wrong question. Instead of “What career should my child choose?”, perhaps we should ask, “Will money ever stop my child from choosing the career they truly want?” That single question changes the purpose of investing.

The freedom to choose

True wealth planning is no longer just about funding engineering, medicine or an MBA. It is about creating options. The great-



est gift we can give our children isn’t a predetermined career, but the freedom to build one on their own terms. Investing for children is often seen as a way to fund college, but it is much bigger. Every investment today expands their choices tomorrow.

If they want to study overseas, pursue research, start a company, work in the arts or follow a less conventional path, financial security can give them the freedom to explore. Your investments won’t decide your child’s future, but they can ensure money doesn’t decide it either.

As investment planners, we often talk about returns, asset allocation and compounding. They matter. But some of the greatest

returns will never appear on an account statement. They’ll show up years later—when your daughter chooses work she loves, your son follows his passion without worrying about money, and your children make choices based on conviction rather than financial pressure. Those are returns no performance chart can measure.

A lesson from children

When my daughter was 10, I couldn’t have predicted what she would become at 22. I doubt I can predict where my son will be 10 years from now. As parents, we feel we must have all the answers. But perhaps that isn’t our responsibility. It is to give our children strong values, unwavering support and, wherever possible, the financial freedom to find their own path.

Life has a way of taking us places we never planned. As I boarded my flight

that day, I realised the advertisement stayed with me because it asked a profound question: What are we preparing our children for—a degree, a profession or a lifetime of choices?

Perhaps true wealth planning isn’t about helping our children become who we imagined, but giving them the freedom to become who they discover. True wealth isn’t preparing them for one future, but for any future they dream of. Your child’s dreams may change. But will your investments give them the freedom to pursue them? Think. Plan well. Live better.

Ravi Kumar T.V. is the co-founder of Gaining Ground Investment Services, an investment services company based in Bengaluru.

OUR VIEW



Teenagers on company boards: let's not rush it

Good corporate governance calls for well-informed boards. India should weigh the rewards of lowering the eligibility age for key board positions against its risks before taking a call

A Parliamentary panel examining India's Companies (Amendment) Bill has recommended reducing the minimum age for appointment as a managing director (MD) or whole-time director (WTD) from 21 years to 18. The committee reportedly had a consensus on this proposal. Perhaps the rationale is to widen the pool of eligible candidates for senior management roles, especially in family-owned businesses and promoter-led companies that often groom the young early for leadership. It would also align India's rules more closely with those in countries like the US, Germany and Australia. The age recommendation, part of an over 1,100-page report tabled in Parliament by the joint committee on the above-mentioned bill, deserves careful thought. Yes, lowering the bar would let youngsters be appointed to company boards. But if one accepts that the *raison d'être* of board-led companies is to ensure better corporate governance, it is not clear how lowering the age of eligibility would help. After all, the board of directors is responsible for holding the company's management accountable and putting in place policies, processes and control mechanisms that can act as a system of checks and balances. In other words, a board position cannot be taken lightly. It pre-supposes a knowledge base that includes familiarity with issues of company governance, law, finance, risk exposure and more, apart from a grasp of the prevailing macro-economic scenario in the country and abroad. In today's context, the latter would include a sound understanding of geopolitics and geo-economics. This is not to say that 18-year-olds are incapable of possessing such knowledge. Or showing maturity. Note

how the voting age for national elections has been steadily lowered in most countries across the world. India reduced its age of eligibility from 21 to 18 years back in 1988. And nobody can deny the importance of electing leaders. That, however, is not an apt comparison. As a series of high-profile corporate scandals in the advanced world (Enron, BP) and closer home (Satyam, IL&FS) has shown, a key differentiator between successful and unsuccessful companies is often the quality of their boards. At present, the Companies Act of 2013 does not prescribe a minimum age for directorship in general, though Section 196 of the Act lays down that a firm's MD and WTDs should not be aged below 21. The Securities and Exchange Board of India's Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements specify 21 years as the limit for independent directors of listed firms. At one level, this might seem to work against young blood on company boards. But a sharp rise in the number of listed companies over the past few years, with many of them led by young promoters venturing into new spaces, has already brought down the overall average age of boards in India. Data compiled by *Primeinfobase.com* shows that the average age of directors across NSE-listed companies has declined to 56.5 years, as of August 2026, from 58.9 years in March 2017, while the number of board seats held by those under 40 has more than tripled. Indian company boards are steadily getting younger. Yet, some cognitive studies suggest that advanced skills like risk judgement often take a few years past a person's teens to mature. Given the criticality of boards in business success, the risk-versus-reward trade-off involved in lowering the bar for board membership would argue for deferring this decision.

MY VIEW | MYTHS AND MANTRAS

Are you treating equities in your portfolio like you do your exes?

Out of sight and out of mind is an ill-advised approach if once-loved stocks are still in your portfolio



DEVINA MEHRA
is founder of First Global and author of 'Money, Myths and Mantras: The Ultimate Investment Guide'. Her X handle is @devinamehra

Think of your exes—you may still nurture tender feelings for some of them, but most are in the category of "Good Lord, what was I thinking when I started dating them" or "fell in love with them" or God forbid, "married them!"

You don't even want to think about them now, do you?

The stocks on the last page of your depository participant (DP) statement, which details your portfolio, are mostly in the latter category. You loved them once but now wonder how you got entangled with something so useless or toxic.

While having nothing to do with your ex may be good for your mental health, avoiding your previously loved stocks can really harm your financial health if they are still lurking on your depository statement.

I have seen stocks like Pentamedia, NEPC Micon, DSQ Software and others sitting in people's portfolios for two-and-a-half-decades and counting. Real life grandparents' portfolios are stuffed with stocks from groups like JK, Mafatlal, Modis, etc that were never sold.

I hear similar stories from many financial advisors and wealth managers. It's the long tail of all but forgotten stocks.

Unfortunately, some of your capital is still tied up there, and if you had got out of them in a disciplined fashion, the

value of many would not have gone down to virtually nothing.

Never forget the golden rule: anything that you would not buy at today's price, you should not be holding in your portfolio.

That is the simple and only valid test. The 'hold' rating exists in the world only because most investors refuse to acknowledge this simple truth.

What happens even more often is that if you buy five stocks and one of them doubles or triples, you book profits on that so that it appears that your portfolio is profitable, whereas you hold on to the ones that fall 40% or 50% or even 70%.

This means is that over time, you get rid of your winners and hold on to a lot of losers and pure junk—the exact reverse of what you should be doing.

Your portfolio becomes a graveyard for the debris of bull markets from the past.

Ideally, you should never sell a stock that has done well simply because it has gone up, say, X%, because if you do that, you will never get the true multi-baggers.

On the other hand, you must be ruthless about stocks that have not done what you expected them to do.

What can you do now? Do not postpone things any longer. This very weekend, grit your teeth and go through your entire DP statement—right up to the last page.

Answer the question that if you had cash today, where would you have invested it.

Get rid of anything and everything that does not make that cut.

No waiting for something to come back to your purchase price or some other mental target you may have. Remember that the market has no interest whatsoever in either the price at which you bought the stock or your hoped-for price.

Unlike you, it has no stories attached to those numbers.

The other statistic to remember is

this: nearly three-quarters of the stocks ever listed on Indian stock exchanges do not even trade anymore. Their price is now zero. Just think about it.

Roughly 4,500 stocks trade actively in the Indian market. The number of stocks ever listed is three to four times that number.

After all, in the 1990s, there were single years when the number of listings were 1,100 and 1,200. Most of those have disappeared into the blue yonder.

That is why the best thing you can do for your portfolio is that when you are making an investment, tell yourself that you may be making a mistake.

Because it is certain that a good chunk of your investments will not do what you expect them to do, partly because the future is uncertain. No one knows what will happen.

This should have been the lesson you took away from the covid crisis. At the beginning of 2020, nobody knew that the pandemic would hit. But suppose you had known that there would be a disruption in the world that would kill millions of people and revenues for several industries—from hotels and aviation to automobiles and many parts of the retail sector—would go to zero, could you have ever predicted that global markets would see a massive bull run later that year? This is how unpredictable life and markets are.

The other part of this equation is that even the best investor or fund manager in the world does not have a hit rate above 60 or 65%. No one has 90% or 100% of their picks doing well.

Warren Buffett? His lifetime average has been that he sold 85% of what he bought within two years and over 50% within six months. So clearly, even after all the study, many of his stock picks did not achieve what he expected them to.

The lesson in all this: look at your present investment mix, salvage what is salvageable and put it in a better investment today. Tomorrow is the start of the rest of your investing life.

10 YEARS AGO



JUST A THOUGHT

The error of youth is to believe that intelligence is a substitute for experience, while the error of age is to believe experience is a substitute for intelligence.

LYMAN BRYSON

MY VIEW | WORLD APART

America's yen intervention promises to get complicated

RAHUL JACOB



is a former Financial Times foreign correspondent.

The scribble on a US Treasury notepad earlier this month might have looked casual, but it was no ordinary to-do list. Scott Bessent's note to buy tens of billion dollars' worth of Japanese yen was photographed and billboarded as a scoop, helpfully telegraphing the US treasury secretary's intention to prop up the Japanese yen. Bessent worked for billionaire George Soros for 13 years, including as his chief investment officer between 2011 and 2015. Bessent's equivalent of holding a placard up for traders around the world worked in the short-term. On cue, the yen rose against the US dollar after that intervention by the US Treasury, which used euros to buy yen.

But it was an unusual event that also cast an unflattering spotlight on the weaknesses of these two highly indebted financial superpowers. As Japan has transitioned from its zero-interest rate policy after ending decades of deflation, the cost of servicing its immense debt has risen—Japan's ministry of finance projects its debt service cost will rise

to 30% of total expenditure by 2029-30, up from just a quarter last year.

Many Western commentators interpreted the US helping an ally as a move driven by self-interest. "Mr. Bessent is doing so to help ensure that Washington's borrowing costs do not (go) even higher," observed *The New York Times*. If the Bank of Japan (BoJ) had sold billions of dollars to boost the yen, it would have driven up US government bond yields, which have steadily moved to more than 5% for the 30-year Treasury "in part because doubts have crept in over the Federal Reserve's true willingness to tackle sticky inflation with higher interest rates," noted Katie Martin, a columnist for the *Financial Times*.

In both the case of the BoJ and Fed, it is abundantly clear that their respective political executives want low interest rates. While Trump has been silent on the subject since his nominee Kevin Warsh took over as head of the Fed, a large part of his open hostility towards former chair Jerome Powell, whom he appointed in 2018, was due to Powell's unwillingness to cut rates, given how entrenched inflation had become. Similarly, Japanese Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi's government is understood to have a tricky relationship with BoJ governor Kazuo Ueda.

Ueda, a long-time academic, has struggled to project the need for higher interest rates even as Japanese consumption and salaries have more than recovered. Unlike, say, Raghuram Rajan when he was RBI governor, Ueda seems unable to make his case to the public. Japanese conventions, such as a representative from the government occasionally sitting in on BoJ rate-decision meetings, have been resorted to; Japan's economy minister has attended meetings time and again since Takaichi took over.

Six months since Takaichi's landslide win for the Liberal Democratic Party, her attempts to bend the BoJ to her looser monetary policy views may cost her in the long run. As the veteran Japan-watcher Bill Emmott, author of the prescient 1989 best-seller *The Sun Also Sets: The Limits of Japan's Economic Power*, observed in a Substack post, the result is a rather muddled economic policy that harks back to the ministry of international trade and industry's pivotal role in Japan's glorious economic ascent in

the post-war decades but will not work well amid Japan's aging crisis.

Nonetheless, as in just about every major economy today, industrial policy rocks. Takaichi, who enjoys playing the drums, polished an image as a catalyst for change. The government has identified 17 sectors, predictably including quantum computing and semiconductors but also the vaguely termed content industry. The overly broad brief for 'Make in India' also suffers from similar mission creep. As Emmott quips, "Looking at the list, it can feel as if the government felt the need to be inclusive, for fear of stigmatising sectors as non-strategic." The government is counting on a staggering 222 trillion yen of private investment.

This boost to private and public spending at a time when labour markets are tight is likely to trigger higher inflation in Japan. The Takaichi government's fiscal policy is also a work-in-progress. The government is likely to slash the consumption tax to 1% on food from next year, in part to soften the

effects of inflation, just when it needs to boost government revenues to fund its ambitious industrial policy and additional defence spending in response to a more belligerent Beijing.

While the US Treasury's intervention in early August arrested the slide of the yen, which had fallen to 163 against the dollar, this week the currency started to fall again to around 159. That the intervention was done without involving the European Central Bank (ECB) and the US used euros rather than dollars suggests a division among international monetary policy authorities. Bessent's experience as a former trader is unquestionable, but his ability to play the international diplomat seems in doubt.

Matters were made worse by a Trump administration official taking the moral high ground by arguing that it respected "the confidentiality of private discussions, unlike the ECB." Bessent's support for Ueda to raise rates may also be an issue with the Takaichi government. And with the yen carry trade—where large investors use low interest rates in Japan to take yen loans to invest in assets elsewhere—such an integral part of financial markets today, US intervention could increase asset volatility. Bessent's to-do list promises to become more complicated.

The US treasury secretary's support for Japan's currency could have unintended consequences



| MY VIEW | ECONOMIC GRAVITY

MINT CURATOR

Here's a four-step policy agenda to help raise India's credit rating

A study of what global rating agencies examine could guide fiscal management in a way that would help deliver upgrades



PRACHI MISHRA
is dean of Ashoka School of Economics and Finance, director and head of Ashoka Isaac Centre for Public Policy, and professor of economics at Ashoka University.

In August 2025, S&P Global raised India's credit rating to BBB, the first upgrade in 18 years. Morningstar DBRS and Japan's R&I followed suit. Fitch and Moody's held theirs, pointing to the same figure: government debt of around 84% of GDP, against a level closer to 60% for countries in India's rating band.

A sovereign rating is a judgement about whether a government will repay what it owes. Agencies publish the factors they consider, including growth, deficits, debt and institutions, but not how much each counts for. New research by Olivier Blanchard, Daniel Leigh and this author fills that gap. With data from more than 130 countries over 30 years, the study examines what ratings respond to and compares it with what economic theory says should matter. Three findings stand out.

The first is that rating agencies care far more about how much a government owes than what it plans to do. Think of a bank that studies your outstanding loan closely and glances only briefly at your repayment plan. Theory says the plan should count for more than the stock of debt. In the data, the weightage assigned to such a plan is not just small, but nearly zero for emerging markets.

The second finding is on growth. When an economy grows faster than the interest rate its government pays, debt shrinks relative to GDP on its own. It is the fiscal equivalent of a mortgage that gets easier as your salary rises. Our research finds that agencies recognize this, but only faintly: the effect is real and correctly signed, yet counts for little.

The third finding is most striking. Two countries with identical debt and fiscal plans can have their ratings differ widely. On an 11-point scale, the study puts ratings for Qatar at 8, China at 6.7, India at 4.1 and Brazil at 2.6 before fiscal differences are counted. The debt level an emerging market can carry before losing a rating of 2 points ranges from over 160% of GDP for Qatar to under 80% for Mexico, with India in the middle. Most of what separates emerging markets in the eyes of the agencies may not be fiscal arithmetic. It could reflect soft credibility, judgements on institutions, transparency and confidence. That is perhaps where the fastest gains are possible, as institutions and transparency are elements a government can shape.

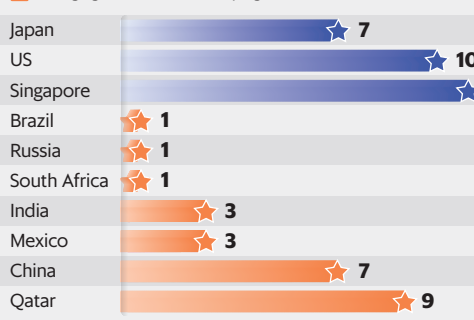
For India, the combined deficit of the Centre and states has come down from a pandemic peak of 13.1% of GDP to about 7.2%, with the Centre having met its targets every year. India has a wide gap between growth and interest rate. Nominal growth runs near 10% while the effective interest rate on government debt sits between 6.5% and 8.5%. Put simply, the economy is growing faster than the cost of servicing its debt, and that gap alone shrinks the debt ratio, all else equal. That makes India's debt level safer than its headline number may suggest.

The S&P credit ratings scatter

Wide gaps exist between the agency's ratings of different countries at similar levels of economic development.

Sovereign ratings of various countries on a scale of 1 (lowest) to 11 (highest)

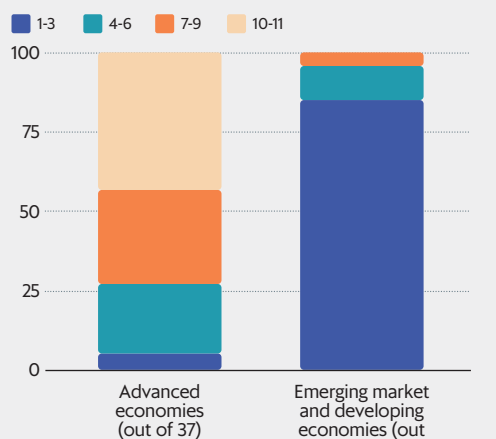
Advanced economies
Emerging market and developing economies



S&P sovereign ratings: 11: AAA, 10: AA+, 9: AA, 8: AA-, 7: A+, 6: A, 5: A-, 4: BBB+, 3: BBB, 2: BBB-, 1: Below investment grade. Ratings are as of 2025 where available, otherwise most recent prior year.

Source: S&P, author calculations

The distribution of economies grouped by ratings (in %)



Source: S&P, author calculations



Yet, rating agencies have been slow to respond. The research suggests why. It's not just about running a primary surplus (revenues minus non-interest spending). Since India's growth outpaces its borrowing costs, a primary surplus would bring the debt ratio down automatically. Ratings do reward that, just not enough. Country effects matter more. They likely reflect the strength of institutions and transparency, not the numbers themselves. So while primary surpluses help, a better rating depends more on addressing those concerns.

Four steps follow. The first is to lower the interest-to-revenue ratio by raising revenues. India spends a quarter of all government revenue on servicing debt, compared with about 9% for emerging markets. Fitch has said explicitly that this ratio is what it watches. The most powerful lever here is also the least used. India's gross tax collection has averaged 19% of GDP, below that of Brazil, China, Russia and South Africa, with an estimated gap of some 7% of GDP between what is collected and what could be. Improving voluntary compliance by simplifying GST would widen India's tax base and improve the metric that rating agencies grade, without cutting the public invest-

ment driving economic growth.

The second is to bring states fully into the story. The Centre collects 58% of government revenue but accounts for 40% of the spending; states collect the remaining 42% but spend 60%. Ratings judge the government as a whole. Yet, markets discipline only the Centre: sovereign borrowing costs respond clearly to central fiscal performance while state bond spreads barely move across states with varying finances. Deepening the market for state loans could let markets enforce fiscal discipline on states. Doing so would strengthen the general government balance sheet that agencies assess.

The third is to bring transparency to what goes unseen. Guarantees, power distribution company arrears, parastatal borrowings and municipal exposures sit in the shadows of emerging-market balance sheets. Because much of a rating rests on judgements outside the visible numbers, transparency is effective. A consolidated statement of contingent liabilities, covering the Centre and states, can turn concerns into measured and bounded ones. A standardized fiscal framework is required given the issues flagged by the Comptroller and Auditor General's latest audit reports on state finances. Disclosure builds confidence, and must move beyond Fiscal Responsibility and Budget Management reports, particularly at the sub-national level.

The fourth is to move towards the debt anchor accepted by Parliament in 2017. Under current settings, projections suggest that India's debt will drift down to 80% of GDP by 2031. Under accelerated consolidation, it would fall to about 79%. Under a more ambitious path, it could reach 77%. Rating agencies would reward this compression.

There is a broader conversation that India is well placed to lead. If ratings weigh old debt heavily, discount a growth advantage and load the rest onto judgements, then fast-growing economies with long-maturity, domestically-held debt are perhaps being assessed more harshly than warranted. That matters because ratings shape borrowing costs, and borrowing costs shape how many roads, grids and schools a country can build. Asking agencies for greater clarity on their assessments will help India and every emerging market in need of debt capital. India has shown fiscal prudence, but needs this effort to yield rating gains too.

The Ashoka Isaac Centre for Public Policy team contributed to this piece.

Can Democrats work out how to win US battleground states?

A test run of progressives and centrists will shape their 2028 game



RONALD BROWNSTEIN
is a Bloomberg Opinion columnist covering politics and policy.

Democratic voters in America are setting up a high-stakes, real-world messaging test in the states most important to their hopes of recapturing the US presidency. The most direct path back to the White House for Democrats in 2028 is to retake Michigan, Pennsylvania and Wisconsin, the three states that President Donald Trump in 2016 and 2024 dislodged from what I once called "the blue wall."

Last week's Michigan primary advanced candidates who embody the Democratic party's competing theories of how best to do so: centrist Jocelyn Benson, its nominee for governorship, and Abdul El-Sayed, a Bernie Sanders-style progressive running for the Senate. Which one performs better in November will offer the party important clues about which approach could build a broader electoral coalition in this must-win battleground state.

Socialist Francesca Hong was the [clear frontrunner] for Wisconsin's Democratic gubernatorial nomination [but lost narrowly to David Crowley, a centrist]. She offered a distinct contrast to Josh Shapiro, a centrist (and possible 2028 candidate) who is seeking re-election as governor in Pennsylvania.

To be clear, this is not only about who can beat their Republican challenger in November. Yes, progressives have much at stake in whether their candidates can win general elections outside deep blue terrain. If El-Sayed loses, it will hugely deflate the party's left. But at a time when Trump's approval has fallen so sharply, he could win without proving that [progressive] candidates can carry their state in a more neutral environment, or with the larger electorate of a presidential election.

That is why the more revealing yardstick in these crucial battlegrounds will be whether progressive candidates exceed, match or trail centrists Benson and Shapiro on the November ballot.

Dan Kinnamen, the swing-state director for the 2024 campaigns of Joe Biden and Kamala Harris, worries that Democrat progressives are likely to underperform.

Early general election opinion polling in Michigan has shown El-Sayed struggling against Republican nominee Mike Rogers among the same key constituencies that largely preferred Representative Haley Stevens in the primary: voters over 50, women without a college degree and African-American voters. In the same poll, centrist Benson was performing at least 15 points better among each of those groups against her Republican opponent, John James.



Democrat dilemma: Centrist or progressive for the next White House run? BLOOMBERG

In Wisconsin, Hong [was expected to] post huge numbers in Dane County—the prosperous, young and well-educated county around Madison. But she was likely to face similar challenges as El-Sayed in both the African-American neighbourhoods of Milwaukee and the state's midsize cities dominated by working-class Caucasian voters. Because Democrats have already maxed out in Dane, Kinnamen says the key to winning a Wisconsin general election is improving in those smaller, blue-collar places. "And those are not the people clamouring for socialist candidates," he says.

By comparison, centrist Shapiro has shown much broader appeal in Pennsylvania. During his first election in 2022, he ran slightly better than Democrats typically do among working-class Caucasian voters while amassing crushing margins among African-American voters and college-educated Caucasian voters. Public polling shows Shapiro in position to replicate his performance with all three groups this year.

Finding the right model in Michigan, Pennsylvania and Wisconsin is vital for Democrats. Those three states have become the pivot in modern presidential politics. Though not carbon copies, the three are strikingly similar demographically, with more Caucasian residents and seniors than the national average, slightly fewer college graduates and much fewer minorities and immigrants. The trio has voted for the same candidate in all but one presidential election since 1980—and that candidate tends to win. Since 1994, they have even elected governors from the same party in every election but one.

The states converge so deeply that veteran Democratic strategist Tad Devine argues they should be thought of as a single big swing state, what he calls 'Mi-Pa-Wi.' Adding Mi-Pa-Wi to the 19 states that have voted against Trump in each of his campaigns, plus Washington DC and Omaha's 'blue dot' district, would net the next Democratic nominee exactly the 270 Electoral College votes needed for the White House.

For that reason, the outcome of the 2026 elections in these states will reverberate across America. Smart Democrats will study whether progressive nominees outrun not only their Republican rivals, but their centrist counterparts. ©BLOOMBERG

| THEIR VIEW

India's diplomatic missions demand a strategic recast

SRINATH SRIDHARAN & ARJUN RAGHAVENDRA M.



are, respectively, a corporate advisor and author of 'Family and Dharma'; and a Supreme Court lawyer and former Indian Revenue Service officer.

Diplomacy now demands a fusion no bureaucracy can supply: political conviction that carries a mandate, domain expertise that can smell the true cost of a concession and world experience that commands a room. The counterpart across the table today is a trade negotiator, defence planner, tech entrepreneur, sovereign fund, central banker or head of government. The envoy who answers them must be prepared to roll politics, finance and world affairs into the same breath.

In April, India's government appointed former Union minister Dinesh Trivedi as High Commissioner to Bangladesh, the first political appointment of its kind under the Narendra Modi government. The significance lies less in the individual than in the question: should an ambassadorship remain the culmination of single-career track, or should India choose every envoy for the capability each mission demands?

India has been here before. The early Republic drew on eminence when the task

demanding it—think of S. Radhakrishnan, Vijayalakshmi Pandit, K.M. Panikkar, V.K. Krishna Menon, M.C. Chagla, Nani Palkhivala, Karan Singh and I.K. Gujral—while treating the Indian Foreign Service (IFS) as the system's spine rather than its ceiling.

That instinct should not be romanticized and the idea is not to diminish the IFS. Its institutional memory, negotiating craft and relationships built over decades are assets that the country cannot casually discard. The IFS should remain the backbone of India's diplomatic architecture. But a spine cannot be the entire skeleton.

Consequential talks today run through semiconductor supply chains, export-control carve-outs, data flows, defence co-production, investment screening and technology standards. Treaties are drafted in detail, covering tariff schedules and technology annexes long before they are announced as political statements. The communiqué is the polish on a structure built by expertise.

India's own ambitions concede the point. The commerce ministry expects missions to deliver export promotion, market intelligence and the removal of non-tariff barriers; Niti Aayog wants structured technology-services trade missions to Japan, Germany and the Gulf. Semiconductor capability, global

capital, technology partnerships—these are clearly diplomatic objectives as much as economic ones.

A tariff line held in Brussels is a factory in Coimbatore. A technology annex in Tokyo is a fab in Gujarat. A co-production clause in Washington is a squadron that flies. A data arrangement with Singapore determines how an Indian technology company scales. The economy-tech-defence triangle is no longer a single theatre of diplomacy, but the whole map, and it requires people who closely understand the substance on the table.

India already accepts the principle in part: defence attachés have long brought military expertise into its missions. Should that logic not extend to a trade economist in Brussels, a semiconductor specialist in Tokyo, a fintech lawyer in Singapore, an investment professional in the Gulf?

Nor should the doctrine stop at the ambassador's office. The second and third layers of a mission—the counsellors and first secretaries carrying a trade brief, technology

file and an investment account—are where domain depth decides whether an agreement becomes an outcome. Build specialist capability into those layers, systematically, while the IFS supplies coherence.

Diplomatic capital compounds through continuity. A mission that links political

access with intelligence, commercial and regulatory understanding and private-sector relationships creates institutional memory beyond one posting. This matters as opportunities rarely arrive by a timetable of personnel rotations; they require persistence, follow-through and the ability to carry relationships across geopolitical cycles.

The lesson from lateral entries to domestic civil services is instructive. India omist in Brussels, a semiconductor specialist in Tokyo, a fintech lawyer in Singapore, an investment professional in the Gulf? Nor should the doctrine stop at the ambassador's office. The second and third layers of a mission—the counsellors and first secretaries carrying a trade brief, technology

As politics, capital, tech, security and trade converge, our outreach must enhance its expertise

Some missions demand a career diplomat's decades of relationships. Others will benefit from political access no bureaucratic authority can replicate. Many need deep expertise in technology, trade, finance or defence. The envoy should be chosen for what would yield best results.

How do we judge returns on diplomacy (RoD)? We must not reduce it to a tally of agreements signed. RoD must cover all economic, strategic and institutional gains, some of which compound over the years. A state that refuses to measure the yield of its diplomacy risks mistaking activity for overseas influence.

India needs greater diversity among its diplomats. The country's foreign-relations challenge is to deploy political envoys, career diplomats and domain specialists in accordance with a broad strategy formulated to maximize the national advantage.

Kautilya understood that an envoy was an instrument of power, not just a conveyor of messages. His ancient classic Arthashastra places a demanding test on the envoy: "Whoever has succeeded as a councillor is an envoy." India should recover that standard. In an age where markets, technology, capital and security converge, choosing an envoy is an act of statecraft.



Powered by **Aditya Birla Sun Life Mutual Fund**

FROM THE
APEX,
SEE MORE THAN ONE
PATH TO OPPORTUNITY.

Two equity long-short strategies
designed to pursue growth
across market segments while
actively managing market
exposure and downside risk.



Introducing

**APEX EQUITY
LONG-SHORT FUND**

&

**APEX EQUITY EX-TOP 100
LONG-SHORT FUND**

Invests across the listed equity universe,
with the flexibility to benefit from both
rising and falling markets.

Taps into the broader market beyond the
top 100, using long and short positions to
navigate changing market conditions.

NFO Period: 10th - 24th August, 2026

Apex Equity Long-Short Fund		
(An open ended equity investment strategy investing in listed equity and equity related instruments including limited short exposure in equity through derivative instruments)		
This product is suitable for investors who are seeking*	Risk-band	Benchmark Risk-band (NIFTY 500 TRI)
- Capital appreciation over long term - An open ended equity investment strategy investing in listed equity and equity related instruments including limited short exposure in equity through derivative instruments.	LOWER RISK RISK BAND HIGHER RISK 1 2 3 4 5 RISK-LEVEL 5	LOWER RISK RISK BAND HIGHER RISK 1 2 3 4 5 RISK-LEVEL 3

Apex Equity Ex-Top 100 Long-Short Fund		
(An open ended investment strategy investing in equity and equity related instruments including limited short exposure in equity through derivative instruments of Ex - top 100 stocks)		
This product is suitable for investors who are seeking*	Risk-band	Benchmark Risk-band (NIFTY 500 TRI)
- Capital appreciation over long term - An open ended investment strategy investing in equity and equity related instruments including limited short exposure in equity through derivative instruments of Ex - top 100 stocks	LOWER RISK RISK BAND HIGHER RISK 1 2 3 4 5 RISK-LEVEL 5	LOWER RISK RISK BAND HIGHER RISK 1 2 3 4 5 RISK-LEVEL 3

*Investors should consult their financial advisers if in doubt about whether the product is suitable for them.
The above product labelling assigned during the New Fund Offer (NFO) is based on internal assessment of the characteristics of the investment strategy or model portfolio and the same may vary post NFO when the actual investments are made.

SEBI Registration No. MF/020/94/8

Investments in Specialized Investment Fund involves relatively higher risk including potential loss of capital, liquidity risk and market volatility. Please read all investment strategy related documents carefully before making the investment decision.